



CENSUS 2027
Method to sort caste data yet to be decided
NEWS » PAGE 4



WESTERN GHATS
Keralam seeks to limit ESA to forest areas
STATES » PAGE 2



WFI CASE
4 wrestlers challenge Brij Bhushan's acquittal
NEWS » PAGE 5



HARYANA'S CRISIS
The villages fighting back against drugs
Residents organise vigils as addiction takes hold
GROUND ZERO » PAGE 7



THE WAIT ENDS
Suruchi, Kamaljeet win first shooting gold
SPORT » PAGE 14

INSIDE



CM Omar moves resolution on J&K Statehood

SRINAGAR
Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Friday moved a resolution on the restoration of Statehood and evoked protests from the Opposition BJP legislators, who tore the resolution, and opposed any move to discuss autonomy or Article 370 in the Assembly. » PAGE 4

AFSPA extended by six months in three States

NEW DELHI
The Union Home Ministry on Friday extended the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act (AFSPA) in parts of Manipur, Arunachal Pradesh, and Nagaland for another six months, following a review of the law and order situation there. » PAGE 5



Several Taliban fighters killed in clash: Pakistan

ISLAMABAD
Pakistani security forces killed several Afghan Taliban fighters after they allegedly attempted to enter Pakistan and opened hostilities along the border in Balochistan province on Thursday, state-run media reported. » PAGE 12

Congress leads nationwide stir seeking CEC's ouster and arrest

Modi and Shah using poll body chief to overcome public opposition through 'artificial manipulation', says Venugopal; party demands reversal of decisions taken by EC, including those related to SIR; civil society groups hold parallel protests

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Friday led nationwide protests demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, accusing him of compromising the integrity of the country's electoral process, with the party's general secretary, K.C. Venugopal, seeking Mr. Kumar's resignation and arrest for alleged electoral malpractice. Civil society groups and other organisations held parallel protests in Delhi and several States.

Congress workers took to the streets across the country, with protests in several places being stopped by the police. Water cannons were used against demonstrators in Patna, Lucknow, and Punjab, while protesters were detained in Assam, Jammu, Odisha, Manipur, and other States. In Manipur's capital, Imphal, the police fired a few tear-gas shells to disperse the protesters.

In Keralam's Malappuram, Mr. Venugopal said the protests would continue until the CEC stepped down. Targeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah, the Congress leader alleged that they were using Mr. Kumar to overcome public opposition to the government through "artificial manipulation".

'Criminal offence'
"Resigning alone is not enough; he must be arrested. What he did is a criminal offence; he must be arrested," Mr. Venugopal said, adding that all decisions taken by Mr. Kumar,



Raising concerns: Youth Congress workers staging a protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, demanding his resignation, in New Delhi on Friday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

including those relating to the special intensive revision, should be revoked.

The party's communication chief, Jairam Ramesh, said citizens and Congress workers hit the streets demanding accountability over the capture of their fundamental right to vote and the "Chief Election Commissioner's diabolical mischief". "The frightened Modi Govt. has cracked down on protesters and detained Congress leaders and workers, young citizens and students, and civil society activists – in so many places across the country," he wrote on X.

Congress leader Pawan Khera told a press conference: "We want to say to Gyanesh Kumar: it's done, bro. Heed Rahul Gandhi's advice - resign and turn approver."

The Congress accused the Election Commission of an "unprecedented attack" on voter equality, al-

leging that a specific 'Mark VIP' feature had been created in the BLO application.

CEC Kumar cancelled two scheduled meetings in Uttar Pradesh. Poll body sources said these were not linked to the protests and were routine decisions.

Citizens' protest

At Jantar Mantar in New Delhi, the campaign drew participation from civil society activists and organisations. The All India Students' Association (AISA), along with civil society members, organised a protest demanding the arrest of Mr. Kumar. CPI(ML) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya, AISA president Neha Bora, activist Yogendra Yadav, lawyer Prashant Bhushan, RJD MP Manoj Jha, activists Anjali Bhardwaj and Nandita Narain were among those who

participated. Several protesters, including Mr. Bhat-tacharya and Mr. Yadav, were detained by the Delhi Police.

Delhi Congress chief De-vender Yadav, who had organised a march from the Delhi Congress office to Nirvachan Sadan, the EC's headquarters, was also detained by the police. Another protest was called by the Students' Federation of India outside Nirva-chan Sadan. The Indian Youth Congress separately staged a protest in Delhi.

New Delhi Deputy Commissioner of Police Sachin Sharma said protesters were detained as no permission had been sought or granted to hold the protest at these venues.

In Patna, the Bihar Congress marched towards the EC office but was stopped by the police using water cannons. Similar protests were reported in Lucknow, where Congress workers

led by State president Ajay Rai clashed with the police after being stopped. In Assam, State Congress president Gaurav Gogoi and other leaders were detained when they attempted to march towards the Chief Electoral Officer's office.

In Jammu, Congress MP and AICC general secretary Syed Naseer Hussain led the protest, with several senior party leaders participating in the demonstration.

The Congress has framed the protests around its "vote chori" campaign, alleging that the electoral roll revision process could exclude legitimate voters. The protests followed Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi's press conference on Thursday on the issue

RELATED REPORTS ON
» PAGE 3

Union Minister says SC/ST MPs not given enough time to speak

EXCLUSIVE

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

Union Minister Jitan Ram Manjhi, in a letter addressed to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, has said that MPs belonging to the Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs) are not "given adequate time" to speak during discussions on important Bills in Parliament.

Mr. Manjhi heads the Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular), an ally of the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

In his letter dated September 16, Mr. Manjhi referred to an "NDA sansad samooch samvaad baithak" (NDA MP Group Dialogue Meeting) held at his residence on August 5.

He said BJP Lok Sabha member Gajendra Singh Patel, who represents Khargone, a reserved tribal constituency in Madhya Pradesh, had pointed out that MPs from SC/ST communities were not given adequate time to speak during discussions on important Bills in Parliament. Mr. Manjhi urged the Lok Sabha Speaker to take steps to rectify it.

Common demand

Mr. Patel, speaking to *The Hindu* over the phone from Khargone, said this was a sentiment expressed by many MPs and not by him alone. He also insisted that it was an "informal" recommendation.

"This issue was flagged by many who were present at the meeting. Moreover, this was something that was discussed informally. Sometimes we get the opportunity and sometimes we don't. Of course, all parliamentarians want



Jitan Ram Manjhi

more floor time," Mr. Patel said.

Mr. Manjhi told *The Hindu* that the NDA MPs' groups meet once every quarter. "These meetings are designed to give a platform to the NDA parliamentarians to air their grievances, and the leader chairing the group then conveys these concerns to the respective Ministry or department.

At the August 5 meeting, Mr. Patel raised the issue on behalf of several first-time MPs from the SC and ST communities. Everyone should have the right to speak in Parliament. That is what I conveyed in my letter to the Speaker," he said.

Recently, Mr. Manjhi made headlines for supporting the sub-categorisation of SC/ST reservation and the introduction of a creamy layer within reservation. He argued that the benefits of SC reservation were reaching only some relatively empowered Dalit communities, while extremely marginalised groups such as the Musahar and Musahar-Bhuiyan communities, which fall under the Mahadalit category, continued to be deprived of these benefits. His Cabinet colleague from Bihar and LJP (RV) chief Chirag Paswan opposed the idea and argued that reservation is based not on economic status but on historical "social discrimination and untouchability".

Four Nagas killed on Manipur border by Myanmar extremists

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Assailants allegedly belonging to Myanmar-based armed groups killed four Nagas from Pilong village in Manipur's Kamjong district on Thursday.

"A Kuki terror group armed with sophisticated weapons crossed the river Namya from Phailen Kuki village of Myanmar and launched a violent attack on Pilong civilians," said the Working Committee of the Tangkhul Naga Long (WC-TNL), the top body of the Tangkhul community. Pilong village is near India's border with Myanmar.

In a statement on Friday, the WC-TNL said the assailants shot dead two residents in the vicinity of the village, while the two others were taken away to

Phailen and killed. It claimed that members of the Kuki National Army-Burma and Kuki elements backed by Myanmar-based People's Defence Force carried out the attack.

"Five residents were keeping watch at Pilong settlement area when the incident took place. One managed to escape and was rescued by a team of Tangkhul civil society organisations," the organisation said.

Third attack

The WC-TNL said this was the third such attack on Naga villagers along the border in Kamjong district.

Despite repeated attacks, the State government and border guards remained "lackadaisical", failing to protect vulnerable villagers living along the border, it said.

Govt. to hold talks with banks and decide subsidy amount for UPI after charges kick in

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI transactions will not be enough to cover the cost of running and maintaining the payment platform, and so the government will soon hold discussions with the Indian Banks' Association (IBA) to decide what quantum of the ongoing government subsidy should continue and in what form, sources in the Ministry of Finance have confirmed.

The Ministry of Finance will also coordinate with the IBA on how to ensure that merchants do not pass on the MDR charge to customers. The MDR charge will go live on UPI on October 15, and there is no proposal to delay this date, the sources said. The government has budgeted ₹2,000 crore for the ongoing

Subsidy shifts

The MDR is set to take effect on UPI from **October 15**, and the government is now considering how much subsidy should continue and in what form. It has budgeted **₹2,000 crore** for the incentive scheme in FY2026-27.

Financial year	BHIM-UPI (₹ crore)	RuPay Debit Card (₹ crore)	Total payout (₹ crore)
FY2021-22	957	432	1,389
FY2022-23	1,802	408	2,210
FY2023-24	3,268	363	3,631
FY2024-25*	1,046	-	1,046

Note: * FY2024-25 figure is actual expenditure as of November 30, 2025; it is not the final full-year expenditure. The FY2024-25 scheme covered low-value BHIM-UPI transactions only, with an estimated outlay of ₹1,500 crore
Source: Department of Financial Services

financial year under its incentive scheme for the promotion of RuPay debit cards and low-value BHIM-UPI transactions.

"The MDR amount that will be collected will not be enough to cover the full cost of UPI," a senior official in the Ministry said on condition of anonymity. "As for the incentive the

government is already providing, we will need to discuss with the IBA on how much should continue and how... We will also be speaking to the IBA in the run-up to October 15 to work out ways in which it can be ensured that the merchants do not pass on the MDR to customers," the official added.

The Finance Ministry will also be speaking to traders and their umbrella body, the Confederation of All India Traders, on the MDR charge and explain to them how most merchants will not be affected, and so should not stop accepting UPI payments.

Issue for GST Council

Another official said that the Ministry could not "unilaterally" decide on the issue of a levy of Goods and Services Tax on the MDR amount collected by payment processors and banks from merchants.

"UPI is a service, and the MDR is the charge for providing that service to merchants," the second official explained. "As such, that service is taxed under GST. But it is for the GST Council to decide on the rate, how much, whether to exempt and all that. The

Centre cannot unilaterally take those actions."

The second official clarified that the GST Council meeting on October 7 will be related to process reforms rather than "any sort of rate issue".

Both officials confirmed that the Ministry of Petroleum will be engaging with the petroleum dealers and their associations to work on their issues regarding MDR. The dealers' associations have voiced their concerns and have asked for a waiver.

"The MDR issue for the dealers is that it will impact their profit margins, and so they have used this as a reason to ask for a review of the margin amount that is decided by them and the Petroleum Ministry," one of the officials explained.

There is no proposal to waive MDR for them, the officials added.

Iran offers to reopen Hormuz if U.S. lifts blockade

Associated Press
NEW YORK

Iran has offered to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and resume talks on its nuclear programme if the U.S. lifts its naval blockade, waives oil sanctions and observes a ceasefire, including in Lebanon. Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi detailed the proposal in a private gathering on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in New York, according to an attendee.

Trita Parsi, executive vice-president of the Quincy Institute think tank, who attended, said Mr. Araghchi suggested that a speedy agreement would help U.S. President Donald Trump ahead of November's midterm elections.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 12

INBRIEF



Security strengthened ahead of Sabarimala pilgrimage

Keralam Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala has said that extensive arrangements will be put in place to ensure the safety of pilgrims during the upcoming Sabarimala pilgrimage. The Minister chaired a high-level meeting on Friday to review preparations by the police. He said that social media campaigns would be organised in regional languages while signboards and public announcement systems would be installed at key locations to provide information to pilgrims.

Karnataka set to launch adventure tourism initiative

With the aim of providing sports enthusiasts a platform to participate in adventure sports while exploring various tourism destinations, the Karnataka Tourism Department will launch ‘Active Karnataka - Run, Ride, Surf and Explore’ on September 27 on the occasion of World Tourism Day. The Tourism department will enter into an agreement with leading sports event organisers and connect them with nearby tourism destinations.

ED summons Telangana MLA in money-laundering probe

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has summoned Telangana’s Serilingampally MLA Arekapudi Gandhi for questioning, as part of its money-laundering probe into Sahiti Infratec Ventures India Private Limited (SIVIPL). Around ₹2.1 crore from the company was allegedly found to have been routed through the MLA’s bank accounts. The ED issued summons asking Mr. Gandhi to appear before the agency on Monday.

Chargesheet in Muttill tree-felling case revised

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

The Forest department in Keralam has resubmitted the chargesheet in the Muttill tree-felling case after rectifying the shortcomings that had prompted the Judicial First Class Magistrate Court-I, Sulthan Bathery, to return the earlier document. The revised chargesheet was submitted in the court on Friday.

The court had returned the chargesheet citing missing documents, clerical errors, and shortcomings in the confiscation proceedings concerning the vehicle allegedly used to transport the timber. It had also questioned the delay in filing the chargesheet.

The court noted that the delay could have been explained by citing the time taken to obtain DNA test results and a government directive requiring forest cases to be filed after the police submitted chargesheets in connected criminal cases. The court had also flagged deficiencies in the investigation, including the failure to trace and produce the remnants of trees allegedly felled on forestland.

The latest submission came amid allegations that omissions in the earlier chargesheet could have benefited the accused, the Augustine brothers.

The Muttill tree-felling episode had resulted in more than 170 cases being registered by the Forest, Police and Revenue departments.

The Forest department alone had registered 52 cases against the Augustine brothers.

Wind-swept



Strong winds continue to lash coconut trees along the RK Beach in Visakhapatnam on Friday, a day after the deep depression crossed the north Andhra Pradesh coast. K.R. DEEPAK

Court to give order on Reporter TV MD’s bail petition today

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Ernakulam Principal Sessions Court has postponed to Saturday its order on the anticipatory bail plea moved by Reporter TV managing director Anto Augustine in the case related to the alleged multi-crore fraud behind the failed bid to bring the Argentina football team, led by Lionel Messi, to Keralam.

Having concluded arguments from both sides on Thursday, the court had reserved its order for Friday. However, the prosecution sought copies of the documents submitted by the de-

fence along with the anticipatory bail application, following which the order was postponed.

Mr. Augustine moved the application anticipating an imminent move to arrest him after the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the case carried out search operations at the headquarters of Reporter Broadcasting Private Limited and locations linked to him and his brothers last week. Incidentally, he was arrested and remanded in judicial custody by the Excise after 67 litres of liquor were seized from his ancestral home in Wayanad. He has since secured bail from the High Court.

Consumer case backlog in Keralam rises by 76%; 26,668 cases pending, says report

Sarath Babu George
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Keralam’s consumer dispute redressal system is grappling with a mounting backlog, with 26,668 cases pending before the State and district consumer commissions, according to a status report submitted by the amicus curiae before the Supreme Court.

The report, filed recently in connection with a *suo moto* case concerning vacancies and inadequate infrastructure in consumer commissions in each State, reveals that the backlog before Keralam’s district commissions has surged by nearly 76% since December 2023, and was nearly twice that of Karna-



The findings raise concern over women’s representation in the State commission. GETTY IMAGES

taka and more than six times that of Tamil Nadu.

Of the total pending cases in Keralam, 22,270 were before district consumer commissions and 4,398 before the State Consumer Disputes Redressal Com-

mission, as of July 31.

Meanwhile, the State commission reported a reduction in its backlog from 4,505 cases at the end of 2025 to 4,398 by July 31, 2026. It disposed of 675 cases against 571 fresh filings within seven months this year.

The report also reveals that one of the cases pending before the Kerala State Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission dates back to December 11, 1995, making it one of the oldest pending consumer disputes in the country.

Female representation

The report also highlights that two of the four sanctioned vacancies in the Kerala State Consumer Dis-

All-woman team to probe POCSO case against businessman

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu police have formed a Special Investigation Team (SIT) wholly comprising women officers to investigate the POCSO Act case against Gem Granites chairman R. Veeramani.

In an order issued on Friday, Director-General of Police and Head of the Police Force Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal said the SIT was formed to probe the case and related matters effectively.

The team will work under the supervision of the Greater Chennai Police Commissioner, who would provide it with the requisite manpower and logistics.

In a related development, a POCSO Special Court in Chennai on Friday extended the judicial custody of Veeramani till October 9 in connection with the case.

The 84-year-old and his alleged accomplices Shanthi and Mahendra Simhan were arrested by the Central Crime Branch on August 29, and remanded in the Puzhal Central Prison. Later, his assistant Ganeshan was also arrested in connection with the case.

‘DMK covered up case’

TVK president and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Friday accused the DMK of covering up the POCSO Act case when the party was in power.

At a campaign meeting



R. Veeramani

for the Madurantakam Assembly byelection, he asked former Chief Minister M.K. Stalin to “reveal what deal had taken place behind the scenes” and criticised the AIADMK, too, for its “silence”, asking if it had an “understanding” with the DMK even on this issue.

He alleged that the main accused had been ruining the lives of young girls for years, but the case history was covered up when the DMK was in power.

The accused had now been arrested.

The victims were children, he said, asking what politics the DMK and the AIADMK had been doing all these years if they could not speak about the children’s pain.

Canvassing votes for party candidate Maragatham Kumaravel, he alleged that the DMK had been continuously spreading slander against the TVK and him, and the AIADMK was “supporting it”.

According to him, a frustrated DMK had taken up the “dangerous weapon” of slandering women.

Heavy showers triggered by depression claim four more lives in A.P.; toll rises to nine

The Hindu Bureau
BUTTAIGUDEM

Four more rain-related deaths were reported in Andhra Pradesh on Friday, taking the death toll during the heavy rain triggered by the deep depression over the Bay of Bengal to nine.

A 60-year-old man was washed away in a swelling stream near Kannapuram in Buttaigudem mandal of Eluru district late on Thursday night.

One person died and nine were injured when a fish-laden lorry overturned near Pathuru village in Eluru district.

Two siblings were electrocuted at Jatlapalem village in the West Godavari district on Friday, pushing the total number of deaths by electrocution to seven.

Meanwhile, the North Coastal Andhra Pradesh region shifted into restoration mode on Friday after the deep depression that crossed the coast near Kalingapatnam brought heavy rain, strong winds and widespread disruptions of public life across the region. While flood fears continued to mount in Sriakulam, restoration and road-clearing operations gathered pace in Visakha-

patnam and other affected areas.

The situation remained particularly critical in Sriakulam, where heavy inflows into the Nagavali, Vamsadhara and Bahuda rivers triggered flooding in low-lying areas.

Home Minister V. Anitha reviewed the flood situation and directed officials to remain vigilant. The Minister asked them to coordinate closely with the authorities in Odisha to monitor flood flows, particularly from upstream areas, and take timely measures to protect people in vulnerable locations.

21-kg Balapur Ganesh laddu auctioned for ₹39 lakh

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The famous Balapur Ganesh laddu, which weighed 21 kg, fetched a record ₹39 lakh at the annual auction on Friday with Sama Praneeth Reddy, founder of Urban Group Private Limited, placing the winning bid.

The auction has become one of the most anticipated events of the Ganesh festival in Hyderabad. It was held after the 18-foot-tall Ganesh idol was taken on a ceremonial tour through the lanes of Balapur. The auction traces its origins to 1994, when a similar offering was sold for ₹450.

Lawyer group calls for fresh hearing in the Noida DM case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A group of advocates issued a public statement on Friday seeking the recall of a recent Supreme Court order involving Noida District Magistrate Medha Roopam and requesting that petitions challenging the Chief Election Commissioner's appointment law be heard afresh.

The statement, issued by the Lawyers Association for Constitution and circulated online by Supreme Court advocate Subhash Chandran K.R., urges that both matters be heard by a top court Bench that does not include Justice Satish Chandra Sharma.

Justice Sharma had led the Division Bench that passed an interim order on September 23 in the appeal filed by Ms. Roopam, the daughter of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

The same day saw Justice Sharma disagree with Justice Dipankar Datta on whether the challenge against the 2023 CEC/EC law should be referred to a five-judge Bench. Justice Datta had decided against the reference to a Constitution Bench, opting to straightaway hear the merits of the case against the

2023 law while Justice Sharma had favoured a reference.

Split decision

Due to the split decision, the matter is now pending before the Chief Justice of India.

The lawyers' group has cited two primary concerns gleaned from public reports. One, on the "improper listing" of Ms. Roopam's case before Justice Sharma's Bench, which did not hold the roster for petitions linked to *habeas corpus* pleas. The association further pointed to "public reports" stating that the "son of Justice Sharma is empanelled as a standing counsel for the Election Commission of India before the High Court of Madhya Pradesh".

"We do not know whether this was brought to the notice of the parties in either matter... We wish to state that we are not on the merits of the case but on how these circumstances may appear to the public. The Supreme Court has long held that the test in such situations is not whether a judge was in fact influenced. The test is whether a fair-minded and informed observer might reasonably apprehend a possibility of bias," it said.

Declaration part of Form 6 changed since SIR in Bihar

The Election Commission uses Form 6 for fresh voter registrations; new voters are now required to furnish details from last SIR, including Assembly constituency, polling booth and serial numbers

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The declaration accompanying Form 6, which was introduced for the first time during the first phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in Bihar last year, has undergone substantial changes in the later phases. The Election Commission uses Form 6 for fresh voter registrations.

In Bihar, the declaration form was sought to confirm the exact period of the birth of a new voter whether it was before 1987, between 1987 and 2004, or after 2004, based on which the prospective voter had to submit documents.

For those born before July 1, 1987, only the applicant's own document was needed to prove date and or place of birth, for those born between July 1, 1987 and December 2, 2004, the applicant needed their own document, along with one parent's document (either father's or mother's) and those born after December 2, 2004, the applicant needed their own document, with documents for both parents (father's and mother's) es-



Fresh tweaks: New voters filling Form 6 had to declare whether their or their parents' names appeared in the last SIR. FILE PHOTO

tablishing date/place of birth.

If either parent was not an Indian citizen, a copy of that parent's valid passport and visa (valid at the time of the applicant's birth) also had to be submitted.

Change in second phase

In the second phase of SIR, new voters filling Form 6 had to declare whether their or their parents' names appeared in the last SIR. They also had to give the Assembly constituency number and polling booth number and the serial number at which the names appeared in the electoral rolls of the last SIR. While filling the form

online in the second phase, if the applicant did not have this information, they could choose the third option, on the ECINet portal. Though the field was not formally marked "mandatory", in practice applicants could not submit the online form without completing it. This addition in the form continued in the third phase, which was announced in May this year.

It is this issue that Election Commissioners Vivek Joshi and Sukhbir Singh Sandhu flagged in separate notes and letters in May 2026 and August 2026, respectively.

Form 6 is attached to

the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. Since it is part of an official rule, it legally counts as part of that rule – the EC cannot redesign it on its own. Only the Union government (through the Ministry of Law and Justice, since these rules come under the Representation of the People Act, 1950) has the power to amend the rules, and therefore Form 6 too.

EC officials maintain that adding a separate declaration form with Form 6 and Form 8 (used for changing particulars) had been approved by the full three-member commission when the SIR process began in Bihar last year and was again ratified in the next phases.

They said that Form 6 in itself was never amended, only a declaration was added. What happened in the online module for filing the form was that the IT department made changes so that a person filling the form does not have to e-sign twice while doing it, they claimed.

The EC officials also said that the power to add the declaration form was upheld by the Supreme Court on May 27.

Plea in SC seeks SIT probe against CEC, audit of poll body

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

A petition filed in the Supreme Court on Friday sought the constitution of an independent, high-powered Judicial Inquiry Commission or Special Investigation Team headed by a retired judge of the top court to probe allegations against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

The plea said such an investigation must encompass, among others, an end-to-end audit of the Election Commission databases and probe the institutional circumstances under which 13 crore names were deleted across 30 States/Union Territories under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR).

The plea filed by Supreme Court advocate Shailendra Mani Tripathi, represented by advocate Chand Qureshi, submitted that Mr. Kumar, in light of the allegations, would be divested of any statutory or constitutional immunity, the CEC remains directly accountable under the law – subject to police investigation, evidence gathering, and regular trial proceedings as an "ordinary accused".

Mr. Tripathi argued that

The plea submitted that the CEC remains directly accountable under the law as an 'ordinary accused'

the allegations raised against Mr. Kumar in an investigative newspaper report did not show any reasonable nexus with his official functions and responsibilities, and included tampering with the electoral roll.

'No reasonable nexus'

The allegations constitute a cognisable offence under Section 32 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950 as well as the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

"Once the logical and legal coherence between the act and the official obligation ceases to exist, the doctrine of 'reasonable nexus' breaks down completely. In the absence of this legal nexus, the statutory protection available under Section 16 of the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners Act, 2023 becomes entirely ineffective," the petition contended.

The petition was filed after *The Indian Express* expose on the poll body.

Patnaik seeks a thorough review of the SIR process

Satvasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Biju Janata Dal president and former Odisha Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik on Friday demanded the resignation of the Chief Election Commissioner following a media expose that pointed out differences in the Election Commission about the Special Intensive Revision.

"Because of strong and sharp differences between various Election Commissioners, the CEC should immediately resign. And the entire process of SIR should be thoroughly revisited," he said. The BJD has been against the SIR process from the beginning, he said.

"The SIR 2026 process was initiated by mapping the 2025 electoral data. Instead of simplifying the process, it was deliberately made complicated. As a result, voters were excluded," the BJD said.

Mamata, CPI(M) mend fences with discussion on EC controversy

Subhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

Setting aside decades-long differences, former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee spoke to Communist Party of India (Marxist) general secretary M.A. Baby on Friday, with both leaders converging on the question of the "declining credibility" of the Election Commission (EC).

The call is unprecedented and comes against the backdrop of a rivalry spanning nearly three decades. Ms. Banerjee quit the Congress to form the Trinamool Congress in 1997 because she believed the Congress's State leadership was too soft on the ruling CPI(M)-led Left Front. In 2011, she managed to defeat the 34-year-old Left Front government. The CPI(M) remained the most strident critic of Ms. Banerjee's 15-year reign, which ended with the 2026 Assembly election.

Friday's phone call came as a result of an outreach led by Mr. Baby following the recent *Indian Express* report that Chief



Rallying cry: Workers of CPI (M)'s Mahila Morcha All India Democratic Women's Association hold a protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, in Kolkata on Friday. ANI

Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar allegedly ignored objections raised by fellow Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi regarding various decisions related to the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls.

Mr. Baby wrote the letter, dated September 23, to

parties working both within and outside the Opposition INDIA bloc. Beyond the INDIA bloc, he reached out to the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), and the Biju Janata Dal (BJD). He also sent the same appeal to the Cockroach Janta Party

(CJP), which is not registered as a political party.

In his letter, Mr. Baby wrote that to protect "constitutional values" and "citizens' right to vote", it is essential that all political outfits meet and deliberate with the "urgency that the situation warrants".

"The people of our country are looking at us

with the hope that all of us will stand in defence of democracy, secularism and the right to vote," he said, asking the parties to find a mutually convenient date and place for the meeting.

Ms. Banerjee, according to sources, was one of the first leaders to respond to Mr. Baby's plea.

Agreeing with him, she wrote, "This is truly an extraordinary situation in which the credibility of the EC and our democracy is at stake." The two leaders spoke over the phone on Friday in a call that sources described as "warm". According to sources, Ms. Banerjee also informed Mr. Baby that she had reached out to Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi to call a meeting of the INDIA bloc at the earliest.

Though the two parties remained part of the INDIA bloc, they have kept each other at arm's length.

Cong., Left stage rallies

Hundreds took part in two different protests in Kolkata on Friday, demanding the resignation of Chief

Election Commissioner and the initiation of legal proceedings against him over issues related to the SIR.

The separate rallies were organised by the Congress party and the Left-affiliated women's rights group, All India Democratic Women's Association (AIDWA). Protesters in the Congress rally burned an effigy of the CEC.

During the AIDWA rally, which started from the Esplanade area, protesters marched towards the West Bengal Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO's) office to demand the reinstatement of what they alleged were names "wrongfully" deleted under SIR.

Taking part in the AIDWA protest was Communist Party of India (Marxist) leader Meenakshi Mukherjee, who alleged that lakhs of people were wronged in the State in the name of SIR, with their names deleted from the voters' lists. "This SIR was politically motivated. Gyanesh Kumar must resign and must be tried under the rule of law. Manoj Agarwal (former

CEO, West Bengal) also can't be spared," Ms. Mukherjee said.

She said that Mr. Agarwal must share responsibility for what happened as a result of SIR because he implemented the orders passed by the CEC, which she alleged disenfranchised lakhs and led to several suicides. "All deleted names have to be restored in the voters' lists immediately because the bypolls and corporation elections are coming up," Ms. Mukherjee added.

The rally was stopped near the Bowbazaar area.

Congress workers held a protest in the College Street area and called for Mr. Kumar's immediate resignation and arrest. The Congress protesters also marched towards the CEO's office, but they were stopped near the Central Metro Station.

"Not just his resignation, we also want his passport to be seized so that he cannot escape with impunity like many other criminals in India have been allowed to escape," a Congress worker said.

EC should dispel confusion in minds of the people, say Bihar NDA leaders

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

The Bharatiya Janata Party felt the heat within its alliance over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise on Friday, as Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) leader Chirag Paswan and Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM) leader Upendra Kushwaha urged the Election Commission of India (ECI) to dispel confusion in the minds of the people.

Both Bihar leaders issued statements amid the demand of the Congress that Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar resign immediately.

Speaking to reporters in Patna, Union Minister Paswan said, "Being a part of

the government, I will not defend anyone. The Election Commission is an independent constitutional institution. If questions are being raised about the Commission, I believe it is the Commission's responsibility, and specifically the CEC's, to strongly present its own side. It makes no difference to me what the Opposition says, because the Opposition's job is to engage in politics. After all, how else would they pursue their political agenda if they do not level allegations?"

He further said, "The Commission should present its position strongly to the people, and that is the beauty of democracy. If people lose confidence in the

election process or if doubts arise, then it's wrong. I feel the Commission should present its side. This is not to respond to Rahul Gandhi or the Opposition, but to ensure that no doubts remain in the minds of the people."

'Lot of confusion'

Mr. Kushwaha, whose party too is part of the National Democratic Alliance, echoed the comments in a post on X. "A lot of confusion has arisen among the people over the controversy related to the SIR. The matter needs to be addressed. To dispel the confusion, the Election Commission should immediately come out with the clarification."

On the other hand, Union Minister and senior Janata Dal (United) leader Rajiv Ranjan alias Lalan Singh came out in support of the EC.

"The Congress raises a hue and cry across the country over a media report concerning the Election Commission. The party ought to review the real reasons for its defeat. Attacking constitutional institutions has been a tradition of the Congress," Mr. Singh said.

Meanwhile, the Opposition Rashtriya Janata Dal burnt effigies of Mr. Kumar at district headquarters across the State, including in Patna, seeking re-election in five States, including Bihar and West Bengal.

Students protest in Jantar Mantar seeking CEC's resignation, arrest

Lavpreet Kaur Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

Protests demanding the resignation and arrest of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar were held at Jantar Mantar and near Nirvachan Sadan on Friday, with police detaining students and political workers. However, later in the evening, protesters said all those detained had been released.

The All India Students' Association (AISA) called a protest at Jantar Mantar over what it described as the "compromise of the Election Commission", while the Delhi Congress marched from ITO towards Nirvachan Sadan. The Stu-



Delhi Police detain SFI activists during a protest outside the Election Commission headquarters in New Delhi on Friday. PTI

dents' Federation of India (SFI) and the Congress's student and youth wings also held protests.

'No permission granted'

New Delhi Deputy Commissioner of Police Sachin

Sharma said no permission had been sought or granted for the Jantar Mantar protest. Police initially said 90 protesters were detained.

Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav and

AISA activist Neha Bora were among those detained. "The agitation would continue until Gyanesh Kumar is arrested and voters whose names had allegedly been deleted are restored to the electoral rolls," said Ms. Bora. Former JNU Students' Union president N. Sai Balaji alleged that police personnel without name tags manhandled protesters and around 200 people remained detained at 7 p.m. Police denied the allegations.

The general secretary of Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation, Dipankar Bhattacharya, accused the EC of undermining the electoral process.

Govt. yet to decide how open-field caste data will be sorted, tabulated

Opposition, OBC groups are against open-column option in 2027 Census; they say 2011 Socio-Economic Caste Census also had an open field to record caste, yielding over 46 lakh caste names; successive governments did not act on it, they add

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

More than a month after the Union government notified the questionnaire for the second phase of the 2027 Census, finalising an open-column method to record caste, officials told *The Hindu* that a decision is yet to be taken on how the government will sort, tabulate, and rationalise the data collected through this method.

Under this method, people who are not from the Scheduled Castes or Scheduled Tribes can enter their caste names in an open column. This is unlike other modes of enumerating castes wherein people have to choose from a list of castes, a method used by the Bihar and Telangana governments in their caste surveys. The open-field method allows people to opt for a “no-caste” option; they can al-



The questions in the second phase include those on caste and fields for family particulars and COVID vaccinations. C. VENKATACHALAPATHY

so choose not to disclose their caste name.

Experts, Opposition parties, and associations representing Other Backward Classes have criticised the decision to use the open-column method, arguing that it is bound to repeat the results of the 2011 Socio-Economic Caste Census exercise, which yielded over 46 lakh different caste names. Successive governments had shelved that report, they

say. A senior government official said that discussions on how to make sense of the caste data returned through the 2027 Census forms have not yet been initiated, adding that this will happen as the fieldwork on the exercise progresses over the coming months.

Apart from the caste question, which has been introduced in India's census forms for the first time since Independence, the

method of sorting and tabulating the data for the other new questions is also in various stages of discussion within the Office of the Census Commissioner.

13 new questions

The second phase of the 2027 Census exercise lists a total of 40 questions, of which 13 are new questions or data fields that were not part of the previous 2011 census. These include the question on caste and fields for family particulars, ID proofs, and COVID vaccinations.

The government official added that once a holistic proposal is prepared by the Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India on the method for sorting the data, this file is sent up the chain to the Union Home Secretary, following which the government will take a final decision, either at the level of the Ministry or the Union Cabinet.

Officials said that each division of the Census office would have to handle the tabulation process for the questions that they are responsible for, after which the file on this methodology is forwarded to the top bureaucrat in the Union Home Ministry.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Professor G.N. Devy, scholar, linguist, and cultural activist, said the Office of the Census Commissioner should have ideally included experts in the discussions on finalising the questions, adding that doubts about the method of post-data collection analysis would have also been addressed at this stage, had the government taken this approach.

The second phase of the Census has already begun in several hilly and remote regions, such as Ladakh and the snow-bound areas of Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, and Jammu and Kashmir.

J&K CM brings Statehood resolution in Assembly amid loud protests by BJP

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Friday moved a resolution on the restoration of Statehood “in continuation of the 2000 autonomy resolution” and evoked protests from the Opposition BJP legislators, who tore the resolution, climbed the tables and opposed any move to discuss autonomy or Article 370 in the Assembly.

“In addition to the Resolutions passed by this House on 26th June 2000 and 6th November 2024, this House calls upon the Government of India for the immediate and urgent restoration of full Statehood to Jammu and Kashmir and resolves that this Resolution be forwarded to Government of India,” reads the resolution moved by Mr. Abdullah in the Supplementary List of Business.

The Chief Minister said this resolution will “neither replace or subsume previous resolutions of the Assembly” like in 2000 and 2024 on autonomy and special status, respectively.



House uproar: BJP members stage a protest in the J&K Legislative Assembly on Friday. IMRAN NISSAR

Cong. MLAs seek CEC's resignation

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Congress legislators on Friday flashed banners inside the J&K Assembly that called for resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar in the wake of the recent controversy over the Election Commission.

During the Question Hour, several Congress legislators stood up and trooped into the Well of

the House with banners and disrupted the proceedings. They flashed banners stating that “there was no democracy without fair elections” and demanded the removal of Mr. Kumar.

J&K Speaker Abdul Rahim Rather objected to the display of the placards. “The Election Commission of India was not under the control of the Assembly. Take your seats, before I take action against you,” the Speaker said.

Trinamool leader Ajit Maity arrested in extortion case

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The West Bengal Police on Friday arrested Mamata All India Trinamool Congress leader Ajit Maity on charges of extortion.

Mr. Maity was arrested by police personnel from the Pingla police station on charges of taking money from a person named Gautam Das. According to the allegation made by Mr. Das, Mr. Maity had promised him a post in the party in return for the money.

Mr. Maity is associated with the Mamata Banerjee backed faction of Trinamool Congress. He was arrested from his residence in Kharagpur and taken to the Debra police station.

Before being taken to Debra police station, Mr. Maity said, “This arrest is for political reasons. I have

faith in the police and administration.”

Mr. Maity won the Pingla constituency in the 2021 Assembly election. However, in 2026, he contested from the same constituency and lost to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) candidate. Mr. Maity is currently the vice president of the Midnapore Zilla Parishad. He was the former president of the West Midnapore organisational district of the Trinamool Congress and later the Ghatol organisational district of the party.

Several former legislators of Trinamool Congress and leaders who are supporting Mamata Banerjee have been arrested after the BJP came to power in the State in May 2026.

The charges against these leaders include violence, extortion, and intimidation.

Calcutta HC overturns relief to Cong. Nandigram bypoll candidate in criminal case

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

A Division Bench of the Calcutta High Court on Friday set aside a Single Judge Bench order granting relief to the Congress's Nandigram byelection candidate, Milan Pradhan, from coercive action in a 2007 criminal case.

The Division Bench, presided over by Chief Justice Ravindra Vithalrao Ghuge, held that there was no provision in criminal law for such interim protection to an accused. It said an accused has the liberty to seek bail after arrest and, if apprehending arrest, can apply for anticipatory bail.

The Bench, also comprising Justice Om Narayan Rai, set aside Thursday's order directing the police not to take any steps against Mr. Pradhan in the



Milan Pradhan

case till October 12.

The Bench observed that the law is the same for everyone and there cannot be a different consideration for a person contesting an election. With the Single Bench order set aside, Mr. Pradhan's judicial remand till October 7, granted by the Contai ACJM Court, will remain effective.

On Thursday, Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya directed the police not to take any steps against Mr. Pradhan till October 12 in

connection with the 2007 case at the Khejuri police station in Purba Medinipur district.

The Court had also directed that he not be treated as arrested in the case.

Mr. Pradhan was arrested by the Purba Medinipur district police on September 18 in connection with the case. The Contai court on Wednesday remanded him in judicial custody till October 7.

Mr. Pradhan faces charges, including of murder and attempt to murder, in the 2007 case linked to the anti-land acquisition movement in Nandigram.

Several criminal cases were registered against him in 2007 at Nandigram and Khejuri police stations in Purba Medinipur district. The byelection is scheduled for October 6, with campaigning ending on October 4.

BJP wins mayoral polls in Rajasthan; holds top post in 9 of 10 civic bodies

Mohammed Iqbal
JAIPUR

The ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) candidates won the mayoral contests at Rajasthan's three biggest municipal corporations in Jaipur, Jodhpur and Kota on Friday.

The party candidate also claimed victory in the election for chairperson of Suket municipality in Kota district by a narrow margin of one vote.

BJP's Sunil Kothari was elected as mayor of Jaipur, while Prasanna Chand Mehta was elected to the position in Jodhpur and Anusuiya Goswami in Kota. The voting figures in Jodhpur and Kota went beyond the declared numbers of councillors of the rival parties.

With these three victories, the BJP now has mayors in nine of the State's 10 municipal corporations. Of the seven corporations where mayoral elections were held on September 21, the BJP won



BJP candidate Sunil Kothari showing the victory sign after being elected the mayor of Jaipur on Friday. ANI

in Ajmer, Bharatpur, Alwar, Pali, Udaipur and Bhilwara, while the Opposition Congress secured the only victory in Bikaner.

Counting after polling

The polls were held through the votes of elected councillors, with counting taking place immediately after polling. Elections in Jaipur, Jodhpur and Kota municipal corporations and Suket municipality were held separately after repolling was conducted in some

wards because of technical glitches during the urban local body polls held earlier this month.

The polling in Jaipur witnessed some tense moments when Congress MLA Rafiq Khan staged a sit-in protest after being denied entry into the municipal corporation premises. Mr. Khan and other Congress leaders alleged that the party councillors were being stopped from casting their votes. Mr. Khan, representing the Adarsh Nagar Assembly constituency

in Jaipur, said he would move a privilege motion on the issue. “The BJP government is making a political use of the administrative machinery,” Mr. Khan said after the protest was lifted on the intervention of officials.

‘Trust party's strength’

BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Friday said the trust earned through “serving the people” was the party's strength, based on which every party worker was confident that the public would give it the mandate to serve the nation for decades to come and the reason why the party keeps coming back to power.

Mr. Nabin made the remarks while addressing a ‘Seva Sankalp Sabha’ at Dadiya near Jaipur. “This confidence comes from serving the people... It comes from winning their trust and working for them,” Mr. Nabin said, while questioning Mr. Gandhi's claim about anti-incumbency.

Congress hopes for calm but storm clouds remain ahead of Punjab polls

NEWS ANALYSIS

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

The absence of a few senior leaders, including former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi, from the Punjab Congress unit's demonstration on Friday in Chandigarh against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar has again raised questions about the party's internal cohesion.

The July 1 revamp of the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee (PPCC) had sparked turmoil in the Punjab unit. Amarinder Singh Raja Warring was retained as the PPCC chief, and Mr. Channi, the Lok Sabha member from Jalandhar and the Congress's most prominent Dalit face in the State, was appointed to lead the election campaign committee in the run-up to the 2027 Assembly election. Mr. Channi and a few other leaders,



Punjab Congress workers at the protest against the Chief Election Commissioner, Gyanesh Kumar, in Chandigarh on Friday. PTI

including Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, Rana Gurjit and Tript Rajinder Singh Bajwa, were believed to be upset with the revamp of the party unit. Their supporters demanded that Mr. Warring be replaced as PPCC president, exposing the factional fault lines within the State unit.

PPCC revamp

With the elections approaching and differences persisting, the central leadership of the Congress brought in Sachin Pilot to replace Bhupesh Baghel, a former Chhattisgarh Chief

Minister, as the general secretary in charge of the poll-bound State. Soon after taking charge, Mr. Pilot asserted that nearly all the leaders in Punjab have assured him of working collectively and unitedly.

Power tussle

Amid the ongoing power tussle, particularly between Mr. Channi and the PPCC president, the senior leaders showed a rare sign of unity by participating in the demonstration on September 9 against the Punjab government in Chandigarh, led by Mr. Pilot, a

former Rajasthan Deputy Chief Minister.

A party source said earlier this week that a meeting regarding the State unit took place at the residence of national president Mallikarjun Kharge, where senior party leader Rahul Gandhi and Mr. Pilot were present.

Mr. Pilot reportedly submitted a detailed feedback report on the affairs of the Punjab unit to the party's top leadership.

The source added, “The situation in the State unit at present is quiet, but it could be like a calm before the storm. The party high command had asked the new in-charge to take a broad view of the PPCC's affairs and issues and share it. The feedback has been given. I am confident the issues such as changes at the top leadership of the State unit will be resolved by next week, after which a possible bus *yatra* led by Mr. Gandhi to kick off the party's election campaign could be organised.”

CMYK A IN-X



Overweight and weak

The UN is unwieldy, and needs to move away from superpower hegemony

The 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) could have been written off as just another year, with another set of speeches delivered on the global multilateral stage. However, this year, the UN’s annual Summit has a unique sense of urgency. This is UN Secretary-General (UNSG) António Guterres’s final session, after a tenure marked by a record number of global crises, conflicts, pandemics, climate disasters and the advent of a dangerous age of Artificial Intelligence. Not since the Second World War have there been so many conflicts; one study recorded more than 65 conflicts across 35 countries in 2025, the highest since 1946. Growing polarisation on every major issue, wars by global superpowers in violation of the UN charter, nuclear threats and the imposition of unilateral and illegitimate sanctions have weakened the UN, which at 81 seems overweight, weak and unrepresentative of the world. This makes it an important year for the world to unite in favour of a strengthened and reformed UN while choosing the next UNSG to guide that process over the next decade. This is an important year for South Asia too, with the election of Bangladesh’s Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman as the President of the UNGA’s 81st session; he will oversee the UNSG’s selection. It was disappointing that the world’s most powerful leaders and those at the heart of the conflicts in Ukraine, Gaza and the Persian Gulf failed to suggest solutions for the future. U.S. President Donald Trump spoke about the possible “annihilation” of Iran, and defended U.S. actions in Venezuela. Much to India’s chagrin, he again claimed to have negotiated peace in conflicts including the 2025 India-Pakistan four-day war. Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian referred to the U.S. and Israel as “murderers, terrorists and assassins”. The Russian President skipped the session, while the U.S. denied visas to the Palestinian delegation. An initiative led by the European Union and a few other countries, co-sponsored by India, to build a Partnership for Multilateralism (P4M) beyond superpower hegemony is well-meaning, but was drowned out by the rancour at this year’s UNGA. For India, this year was significant as the Narendra Modi government launched a campaign for a second two-year non-permanent term in the UN Security Council in 2028-29. It was therefore surprising that Mr. Modi decided to skip the UNGA speech this year, and the multilateral summits on the side-lines, fresh from his hosting of the Delhi BRICS Summit. India’s voice, of a balancing power that speaks for a rules-based international order based on the UN Charter, diplomacy and dialogue, is needed more than ever amidst the global warmongering.

Narrowed posture

Karnataka must not reject the full framework of eco-sensitive areas

The Kasturirangan Report bears a pro-development attitude that allows human occupation and a range of economic activity across the Western Ghats, yet the Karnataka Assembly unanimously repudiated its recommendations. A grievance concerned the accuracy of the remote-sensing and satellite data from 2012 that the Report uses to distinguish natural from human-dominated landscapes. Another concern was its recommendation that an entire revenue village be placed within an ‘ecologically sensitive area’ (ESA) if at least 20% of its area is sensitive. This could bring farmland and human settlements within the ESA even when sensitive areas occupy only a fraction of the village. Following the Centre’s directive to States in 2013-14 to begin ground-truthing the Report’s recommendations, Karnataka faced bipartisan opposition centered on concerns about livelihoods, with vested interests, including stakeholders of activities both the Gadgil and the Kasturirangan Reports restrict/ban such as mining, allegedly fanning fears of displacement. The State thus elected to resist the ESA framework. Although the Assembly’s resolution proposes returning to the unfinished task of producing an alternative map, the government’s posture also faces a wider challenge. The Centre’s interim directions in 2013 preserve some protection for the ecosystems that the State stewards, but for the government and the businesses within potential ESAs, the delay may prolong uncertainty over what forms of planned development will ultimately be permitted. Broadly, particular States confront the economic and political consequences of local resistance and foregone development while the country as a whole will capture much of the national benefit of conserving the Ghats, so States have an incentive to negotiate the ESAs’ extent down. However, as of mid-2026, Gujarat was reportedly close to an agreement with the Centre, Tamil Nadu had no substantive disagreement, Kerala wanted to reduce its already ground-truthed 9,993 sq. km to 8,805 sq. km, and Maharashtra and Goa wanted 378 and 21 villages omitted, respectively. These instances of progress (such as they are), the Ghats’ continuity across six States, and the Centre’s 2024 decision to allow ESAs in the region to be notified State by State increase pressure on Karnataka without legally binding it to its neighbours’ choices. Specifically, Karnataka’s ability to continue rejecting the framework as a whole becomes harder to sustain if it does not also produce an equally considered alternative. Karnataka needs to reconcile the apprehensions of its farmers and workers with the responsibilities accruing to the State with the largest share (by area) of the proposed ESAs.

Urged to ban tobacco, Napoleon III, Emperor of France (1852-70), replied, “This vice brings in one hundred million francs in taxes every year. I will certainly forbid it at once – as soon as you can name a virtue that brings in as much revenue.” His uncle, Napoleon Bonaparte, is also credited with calling vices “very good patriots” (though the attribution is uncertain), while Ralph Waldo Emerson observed that “tobacco could cheerfully carry the load of armies”. Different voices, one hard-headed insight: vices are fiscally invaluable. Yet, every age has moral crusaders whose puritanical zeal to ban tobacco, alcohol, or lotteries rests on the misconception – and conceit – that the state can extinguish persistent demand simply by declaring an activity unlawful. Pragmatists know better: a prohibition may be morally appealing yet administratively futile – or, worse, positively counterproductive. The United States learnt this lesson the hard way. Following a sustained temperance campaign, it imposed prohibition through the Eighteenth Amendment and the Volstead Act, from 1920 to 1933. While suppressing legal supply, prohibition left demand intact, fuelling a lucrative black market controlled by violent syndicates such as Al Capone’s. Bootlegging corrupted public institutions, deprived governments of excise revenue and imposed heavy enforcement costs. The Twenty-First Amendment repealed prohibition, recognising that a regulated and taxed market could cause fewer harms than an unenforceable ban. States in India that have experimented with prohibition have faced similar challenges.

The argument for regulation Lotteries are undoubtedly a vice, though arguably less pernicious than tobacco or alcohol. They disproportionately burden poorer households, encouraging them to stake scarce income on remote chances of reward. Rapid draws and instant games can encourage compulsive play and loss-chasing, while giant jackpots distort risk perception. Credit sales, opaque odds and manipulative advertising compound these harms. These are powerful arguments for stringent regulation, not necessarily prohibition. Lottery bans can push players towards smuggled tickets, *matka*, *satta*, single-digit rackets and offshore portals. Operating through cash agents and mule accounts, these enterprises lack audits and age restrictions, secure prize funds and effective remedies against fraud. Governments lose lottery surpluses and GST revenue, while legitimate vendors, many of them poor or disabled, lose livelihoods and enforcement costs rise. In seeking to protect the vulnerable, the state may instead leave them at the mercy of unaccountable operators.



K. Ashok Vardhan Shetty
Retired IAS officer, a former Vice-Chancellor of the Indian Maritime University, Chennai, and Member, The Justice Kurian Joseph Committee on Union-State Relations

Regulation, not prohibition, can curb lottery harms while preserving accountability

Revisiting India’s nuclear doctrine without revising it

India’s nuclear doctrine has remained largely unchanged for over two decades, even as its security environment has shifted dramatically. Since its operationalisation in 2003, China’s military rise has accelerated, Pakistan’s nuclear posture has evolved, disruptive technologies have reshaped deterrence, and geopolitical competition has become more multipolar. Yet, the doctrine’s core principles – credible minimum deterrence and a declared No First Use (NFU) posture – have endured, albeit with a specific provision retaining the option of nuclear retaliation following a major biological or chemical attack on India or Indian forces. The question is whether a framework crafted for the early 2000s remains fully aligned with the security challenges of the mid-2020s.

A doctrine for another era, strategic shifts India’s nuclear doctrine emerged from the distinct strategic context of the late 1990s. The 1998 Pokhran-II tests established India as a nuclear weapons state, while Kargil (1999) showed that nuclear deterrence did not rule out conventional war. The 1999 Draft Nuclear Doctrine and the Cabinet Committee on Security’s January 4, 2003 decision sought to reconcile deterrence with restraint. The 2003 decision operationalised a posture based on credible minimum deterrence, No First Use (NFU) and massive retaliation to a nuclear attack, supported by a survivable second-strike capability and firm civilian control. Judged by its original objectives, the doctrine has provided continuity, predictability and strategic stability for more than two decades. The question is whether the assumptions underpinning it remain stable. The strategic environment underpinning the framework has changed in three important ways. First, China and Pakistan have grown more strategically aligned. When the doctrine was



Advitya Madan
Analyst on geopolitics, international and defence affairs, commanded 15 Punjab in Lebanon under the United Nations Flag, commanded 27 Sector as DIG in Churachandpur, Manipur, and was Brigadier Operational Logistics in HQ Western Command

India’s nuclear doctrine faces new strategic, technological and geopolitical challenges

formulated, the two nuclear-armed neighbours posed distinct challenges; today, those challenges are increasingly interconnected. China has expanded and modernised its nuclear forces, strengthened military infrastructure along the Line of Actual Control and deepened defence cooperation with Pakistan. Pakistan has diversified its nuclear capabilities, including tactical nuclear weapons intended to offset India’s conventional advantage. India must therefore account for the possibility that pressures from two closely aligned nuclear adversaries could interact during a crisis. The second shift is technological. Artificial intelligence, cyber capabilities, space-based surveillance, hypersonic weapons and ballistic missile defence are reshaping deterrence by shortening decision-making timelines, increasing the vulnerability of command-and-control networks and complicating assumptions about assured retaliation. These technologies do not invalidate the doctrine’s core principles, but they alter the environment in which they must operate. Nuclear deterrence ultimately depends on the alignment of doctrine, capability and survivability. The third shift is geopolitical. The Indo-Pacific has become a key arena of great-power competition, while the international system has grown more multipolar. U.S.-China rivalry, closer China-Russia coordination and India’s expanding partnerships have reshaped the security environment. Nuclear doctrine can no longer be viewed solely through bilateral deterrence; regional crises are increasingly shaped by wider geopolitical competition. **Review, not revision** Strategic doctrines are policy instruments, not immutable documents. In India’s case, a review could examine emerging technologies, command-and-control resilience, second-strike

capabilities and the continuing relevance of existing concepts, including the doctrine’s approach to retaliation. The issue of massive retaliation deserves scrutiny. Pakistan’s tactical nuclear weapons were intended to complicate India’s response options below the level of strategic exchange. A review could assess whether India’s declaratory posture provides sufficient deterrent clarity across nuclear contingencies, without necessarily changing its core principles. There are, however, reasons for caution. India’s doctrine has reinforced its image as a restrained and responsible nuclear power while providing continuity in deterrence. Ambiguity over established principles, particularly NFU, could create uncertainty, encourage adversaries to recalibrate and complicate crisis management. The priority, therefore, should be to strengthen operational capabilities, modernise delivery systems and improve command-and-control resilience rather than reopen declaratory policy. A review of NFU need not mean abandoning it. It could reaffirm its rationale, clarify its scope and ensure that supporting capabilities remain credible. Reviewing a doctrine is not the same as revising it. **Building credible capabilities** For India, any doctrinal review should also assess survivability, command and control, intelligence, early warning, cyber resilience and the nuclear triad. The aim should be to ensure that India’s declared policy remains backed by credible capabilities in a changing strategic environment, while aligning nuclear policy with its broader diplomatic objectives and strategic autonomy. Ultimately, a nuclear doctrine is an instrument of statecraft, not an immutable policy. India’s commitment to restraint, credible deterrence and responsible nuclear stewardship remains an enduring strategic asset.

while Sections 5 and 6 empower States and the Union Government, respectively, to prohibit lotteries that violate Sections 4 and 5.

Two necessary amendments Settled Supreme Court jurisprudence treats gambling, including State-organised lotteries, as *res extra commercium*, outside the protections of Articles 19(1)(g) – fundamental right to trade – and 301 – freedom of trade across India. Section 5 of the Lotteries (Regulation) Act, 1998, reflects this principle by allowing States to prohibit outside lotteries. A parallel doctrine applies to potable alcohol, allowing States to restrict or prohibit out-of-State consignments. Yet, in *B.R. Enterprises vs State of U.P.* (1999), the Court read Section 5 down: a State may exclude other States’ lotteries only by abandoning its own and becoming wholly lottery-free. This all-or-nothing rule is difficult to justify. While a State directly oversees its own lottery administration, its oversight of another State’s operations within its territory is necessarily indirect, even as it bears the local enforcement burden. This disparity in regulatory control underpins the case for excluding other States’ lotteries. Faced with this revenue-regulation trade-off, Tamil Nadu (2003) and Karnataka (2007) chose total prohibition, thereby forfeiting the option of running accountable public lotteries of their own. Parliament should amend Section 5 to clarify that the provision applies “whether or not the prohibiting State organises a lottery of its own”. Destination-State consent should be decisive, subject to uniform treatment: a State must either admit all outside lotteries or exclude them all. Smaller States, especially in the northeast, may fear exclusion from larger markets, but compulsory access is no remedy. A new Section 4A should authorise two or more States to establish a common lottery by agreement, pooling players, prizes, technology and costs, as in successful multi-State lotteries elsewhere. Transparent regulation offers a more accountable alternative to prohibition. Section 4 permits States to sell tickets directly or through distributors or agents. While marketing agents may provide guaranteed revenue, departmental operation can be more transparent and enable retail distribution through small vendors, persons with disabilities, women’s self-help groups and cooperatives, broadening livelihood opportunities and limiting intermediary capture. Kerala follows this model. In FY 2023-24, it earned ₹2,883.80 crore – ₹1,129.71 crore in net lottery revenue (or surplus) and ₹1,754.09 crore in State GST. It channels lottery surpluses into health care and welfare. Kerala’s public-operator model offers a useful, though not exclusive, template for reform.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Sanctity of public office
The desire to cling to office indefinitely, while disregarding transparency, accountability, the Constitution and the law, appears to have become the new norm in India. The values of humility, transparency and accountability in public life seem to have become things of the past, especially under the

government of the day. Its top leader may have many achievements to his name, but he has also encouraged an office-centric political culture within the BJP and among those joining it from other parties. The priority appears to be retaining office rather than upholding the sanctity of constitutional democracy. Leader of the Opposition (Lok Sabha) Rahul Gandhi

has urged Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar to resign (Page 1, September 25). Why should Mr. Kumar, when he has the backing of those at the top? The Election Commission of India’s constitutional responsibility is to ensure free and fair elections, and its decisions must command public confidence. The question is: why should constitutional

institutions not function in the letter and spirit of the Constitution and the law? Holding a constitutional office means little if its occupant does not uphold the values and the responsibilities attached to it. **P.K. Sharma,** Barnala, Punjab
Resignation demand If the Chief Election

Commissioner of India quits, will all the deleted names be included in the Special Intensive Revision list? Conducting elections in a country such as India is a huge task because of its large population. In the last round of elections held in some States, the process was appreciated by many developed countries, whose representatives had said that the elections were

conducted in a free and fair manner. All appreciation goes to the Election Commission of India. Demanding the resignation of hardworking people with clean hands will only affect the country. **K.V. Sundaravelu,** Bengaluru
Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address and the full name.

GROUND ZERO



Rajthal residents in Hansi, Haryana, keep round-the-clock vigil at the village entrance to prevent entry of drug peddlers. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

The villages fighting back against drugs

The drug menace has spread from the borders of Haryana to the State's agricultural and semi-urban heartland, forcing khaps, gram panchayats, and community groups to step in where police action alone has failed to contain it. Communities are resorting to night patrols, fines, and direct action against peddlers.

Ashok Kumar reports on these efforts and the widening gap in de-addiction and rehabilitation facilities

On the side of a busy road cutting through Rajthal village in Haryana's Hansi district, around 150 kilometres north-west of Delhi, stands a bright red-and-white banner tied to a yellow police barricade. In bold letters in Hindi, it reads, "*Nasha ke khilaf gram panchayat Rajthal ka sakht sandesh* (The strict message from the Rajthal gram panchayat (village council) against drug/substance abuse)." The warning below says: sell drugs in the village and pay ₹1 lakh; help a drug peddler get bail and pay another ₹1 lakh.

A few steps behind the barricade, men wearing white kurtas and turbans sit on red plastic chairs in a circle in the shade of a roadside tree. They are Rajthal's round-the-clock *thekri pehra* (community-led vigil). Their job is to guard their village and the entire stretch against drugs.

Satyawan Singh, 65, says, "We have taken it upon ourselves to not just rid our area but also the entire State of drugs. The Satrol khap, Nau-gama khap, and Bara khap (the names of various khaps active in Hisar and Hansi) have extended support to us, which has given our campaign new strength. Since then, we have become even more active and have started reaching out to every village grappling with the drug problem."

According to the police and locals, the drug crisis first took hold in Haryana's districts bordering Punjab and Rajasthan – Sirsa, Fatehabad, Jind, Kurukshetra, Kaithal, and Ambala – as heroin, locally known as *chitta*; poppy husk; and pharmaceutical drugs made their way across porous State borders. From these entry points, local dealers and small-time peddlers gradually built their own networks, carrying the trade deeper into the State's agricultural and semi-urban heartland, into districts such as Hisar, Hansi, Rohtak, Sonapat, and Panipat.

The trade has grown exponentially over the years. As per the Magnitude of Substance Use in India-2019 report, commissioned by the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment and conducted in collaboration with the National Drug Dependence Treatment Centre, All India Institute of Medical Sciences, New Delhi, 5.9 lakh people in Haryana need help for opioid-related problems. This is the third-highest number among States, after Uttar Pradesh (10.7 lakh) and Punjab (7.2 lakh).

Haryana is also among the States with the highest proportion of its population affected by opioid use, along with Punjab, Delhi, and several northeastern States – Mizoram, Nagaland, Arunachal Pradesh, Sikkim, and Manipur. The report estimates that 1.2 lakh people in Haryana need help for sedative use, putting it among the six States with the highest usage. Another 55,000 people in the State inject drugs, the sixth highest in the country.

As addiction has spread and concerns have grown over the efficacy of police action, villages have begun looking beyond the State machinery for ways to contain the problem. Khaps, social organisations, and gram sabhas have formed

We had reached a point where drug users and sellers had turned the village into a marketplace. People would enter homes and stand in queues to buy smack, *chitta*, ganja and other drugs.

ANIL GODARA
Brother-in-law of the Sarpanch in Rajthal village

committees to monitor suspected drug peddlers and even impose their own deterrents.

Keeping vigil

Residents say the drug problem in Rajthal, on the Jind-Hansi link road, has been around for nearly a decade, but it has worsened sharply over the past three years. They allege that the number of houses involved in selling drugs has increased from two or three to 25 or 26.

With the spread of drugs has come a rise in thefts, particularly from agricultural fields, say residents. They allege that to finance drug consumption, copper wires from submersible pumps, motorcycles, utensils, and other articles are stolen and sold as scrap.

"We had reached a point where drug users and sellers had turned the village into a marketplace," says Anil Godara, 38, the brother-in-law of Sarpanch Renu Devi. "People would enter homes and stand in queues to buy smack, *chitta*, ganja and other drugs."

According to Poonam Devi, 38, a yoga teacher working in the Haryana Kaushal Rozgar Nigam, a government department, the spread of drug use in Rajthal has changed the way women move through public spaces. "Those who use drugs stare in an improper manner at women. Sometimes they try to stop women riding scooters when they are returning from work," she says.

Devi says the bus stand has, in particular, become a place of concern. Women who park their scooters or motorcycles there are often warned by shopkeepers that their vehicles could be stolen by drug users. She says a bicycle and a motorcycle have been stolen from the area.

For girls and women going to school or college, the fear extends beyond theft. "We do not even feel safe wearing bangles or chains," she says. Women who once moved around the village freely in the mornings and evenings now often go out accompanied by men, she adds.



The poster in Rajthal warns that selling drugs in the village will attract a fine of ₹1 lakh; helping a drug peddler get bail will attract a fine of another ₹1 lakh. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Alarmed by the spread and addiction to drugs, locally known as *sukha nasha* (dry intoxicant), as well as the spurt in thefts, the residents of Rajthal approached the district administration and the police to seek their support in launching their initiative. They also held a gram sabha meeting, where residents across age groups agreed to participate in the campaign. The village then formed the *thekri pehra* at two points to keep a watch on people and vehicles entering and leaving Rajthal.

The *thekri pehra*, launched on August 26, involves groups of young men keeping watch, with 15-20 people stationed at each point after 9 p.m. During the day, the number of villagers, including the elderly, can rise to 50-60 or more. Village youth also ride motorcycles to chase people suspected of entering the village to buy drugs.

This practice has a history. The Punjab Village and Small Towns Patrol Act, 1918, outlines "the performance of nightly patrol duty by the inhabitants of villages...in case of emergency."

Residents say they have caught more than 400 people so far, including students, farmers, youth from well-off families, and a few girls aged 17-18. In several cases, parents have learned about their children's drug use only after the villagers informed them, say residents.

Ankur Bisla, 30, who is part of the *thekri pehra* team, says most of those caught consuming drugs are from Haryana, including neighbouring villages and areas around Panipat, Sirsa, and Sonapat. "Some of them had travelled from Gurugram as well," he says.

However, the job is not easy. After the vigil restricted the movement of outsiders into the village, drug sellers have become cleverer by taking supplies outside the village. Residents say they have noticed vehicles leaving the village in the wee hours, between 1 a.m. and 4 a.m.

Hansi Superintendent of Police Vinod Kumar says community participation has become an important part of the police campaign against drugs. In response to the villagers' demands for greater police presence, the police deployed four personnel, including a woman constable, along with a police control room vehicle and a checkpoint, a month after the campaign was launched.

On September 23, around 150 police personnel and a canine squad conducted a three-hour house-to-house search operation in the village. "But such operations can be challenging as people often get alerted by police activity and move or conceal contraband," he says.

When the people take over

Independent journalist Vijender Kumar, who runs a YouTube Channel called NewsMike24, says there is a history of illicit liquor trade in some of these villages. He says what was once largely confined to liquor has evolved into a more dangerous drug market, increasingly involving women too, and affecting the youth from poor families. The survey highlights the vulnerability of children: Haryana has 35,000 children who need help for inhalant use, the fourth-highest number among the five States with the highest figures.

The emergence of heroin is particularly worrying, says Kumar. He points out that 5.7 kg of heroin was seized in Jind alone a month ago, valued at around ₹11 crore in the international market.

Kumar says the fight against drugs in Haryana's villages is increasingly being led by residents. He recalls how Ashrafgarh-Dauri village in Jind, close to the Punjab border, confronted the problem about two years ago. "Villagers formed a 20-25-member team comprising the youth, government employees, retired people, and ex-servicemen to maintain round-the-clock vigil. They installed 25-26 CCTV cameras outside the houses of alleged drug sellers and imposed fines. The number of people coming into the village to buy drugs reduced," he says.

Lochab village, once a drug hotspot, also brought drug activity under control after the panchayat imposed fines and took strict action. "But



The police focus on curtailing the commercial supply of drugs, but the combination of the dark web, cryptocurrency, and courier services has changed the way drugs are trafficked.

RAJENDAR KUMAR MEENA
Deputy Inspector General of Police,
Haryana State Narcotics Control Bureau

new hotspots have emerged in Rajthal, Petwar, and Sulchani, where drug supply remains high," says Kumar.

Rajthal resident Ratan Sharma says the police are reluctant to conduct searches in cases involving small quantities of drugs. "They say they cannot register a case over one or two packets. But if searches are not conducted, how will larger quantities be recovered," he asks.

Sagar Preet Hooda, Director General of Police (DGP), Chandigarh, and a native of Haryana's Rohtak, has conceptualised a village-based programme that brings local residents together to tackle the growing drug problem as a community-led social intervention. Called the Panchgama development model, the programme will be launched in Jind on October 11. In its first phase, it will cover nearly 300 villages, grouped into 60 clusters of five villages each.

"Through the Jind social forum, volunteers with roots in Haryana will share their experiences, expertise, and networks to support rural youth. They will work alongside existing community and government institutions," he says.

Several khaps, too, have announced that they will impose fines on those indulging in drug-peddling in view of the growing problem.

Even as communities are taking matters into their own hands, Bisla questions the lack of political will in dealing with the growing menace. "On the one hand, the BJP has launched the Nasha Mukht Punjab Yatra (an anti-drug political campaign) in neighbouring Punjab. On the other, it has done precious little to contain the menace in the State that it has governed for the past 12 years," he says.

State measures and hurdles

As part of its efforts to combat the drug menace, the State government constituted the Haryana State Narcotics Control Bureau (HSNCB) on August 25, 2020. So far, 2,353 FIRs involving commercial quantities of narcotics have been registered under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985, and 6,256 accused people have been arrested, according to a press conference held in June this year by Additional Director General of Police, HSNCB.

In a parallel crackdown on drug-derived wealth, assets worth ₹72.70 crore have been seized, frozen, or attached to date. As part of the campaign against habitual and organised traffickers, preventive detention orders were issued against 156 accused under the Prevention of Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1988. In addition, property attachment proceedings were initiated against 432 individuals to target illegally acquired assets generated by the drug trade.

Rajendar Kumar Meena, Deputy Inspector General of Police, HSNCB, says that going by drug seizures, heroin is the most prevalent in the districts bordering Delhi – Gurugram, Faridabad, Jhajjar – followed by cocaine, MDMA (a synthetic psychoactive drug), ganja, and poppy straw. "The police have a three-pronged strategy to combat the drug menace – enforcement, awareness, and de-addiction," says Meena, conceding that supply cannot be totally curtailed till the time that there is demand.

"The police focus on curtailing the commercial supply of drugs, but the combination of the dark web, cryptocurrency, and courier services has changed the way drugs are trafficked."

The gaps in rehabilitation

Vipin Sharma, the founder of Ankush Foundation, a drug rehabilitation centre in Hisar, says Haryana's response to addiction remains focused on de-addiction and regulatory compliance and gives little attention to long-term rehabilitation.

After more than two decades in the field, Sharma, a recovering addict himself, says the biggest problem is that policies are often framed without consulting those delivering services, such as rehabilitation and de-addiction programmes, on ground.

Sharma argues that frequent inspections and increasingly prescriptive rules have made it harder for rehabilitation centres to function effectively. "Rules requiring clinical psychologists at every centre don't take into account the limited availability of trained professionals. There is also excessive focus on specifications, such as the distance between beds. These requirements divert attention from the central problem of treating addiction," he says.

For Sharma, the largest gap is the absence of sustained rehabilitation after medical treatment. "De-addiction is a medical treatment. It can address physical dependence on a substance, but it is not the complete solution," he says. "Without long-term rehabilitation, a patient's psychological dependence is not addressed."

Sharma says Haryana lacks a rehabilitation centre run or supported entirely by the State government (there are eight centres in the State supported by the Union government). Private centres operate without government assistance, but face regulatory and licensing hurdles.

An inmate at the rehabilitation centre says, "For an addict, quitting drugs is only the beginning. The real battle is staying away from them – a struggle that can last a lifetime." Recovery, he says, cannot end at the centre's gates; it requires the continued support of family and society to help those battling addiction rebuild their lives and find their way back into the mainstream.



At a crossroads: Tashkent Paikada, a settler farmer at Melukavu in the eastern high ranges of Kottayam, walks through the confluence of two mountain streams that flow down to form the Meenachil river. VISHNU PRATHAP

Zones of worry

Keralam is once again witnessing a heated debate over the inclusion of some of its villages in the Western Ghats region in the ESA category. **Hiran Unnikrishnan** and **Sandeep Vellaram** meet the stakeholders, including the settlers of the region and conservationists, to understand their concerns

It is barely noon, but dark clouds have already gathered over Randattumoonni, a hill hamlet deep inside Melukavu in the eastern high ranges of Kottayam. A cool breeze sweeps across the slopes before rain suddenly comes down in sheets, plunging the settlement into near darkness.

“It used to be even darker here when it rained,” recalls Tashkent Paikada, a settler farmer.

For those like Tashkent, these hills are not an untouched wilderness but a landscape shaped by generations of farming and settlement.

They fear that the proposed Ecologically Sensitive Area (ESA) notification for Western Ghats villages will uproot them from their lives, which were built by fighting inclement weather and marauding wildlife.

The seventh draft notification, the latest one in the series, issued on July 27, proposes to bring 9,993.7 sq km across 131 villages in Keralam under the ESA regime. Of this, 9,107 sq km is forest and 8,86.7 sq km is non-forest area. The deadline for filing objections was September 25.

Though the draft notification prohibits mining, quarrying and sand mining in the notified areas, there are no restrictions on the repair, extension or renovation of existing residential houses or on changes in ownership.

But in the high ranges, the notification has once again stirred fears about the impact of the classification on land, agriculture and everyday life. Tashkent remembers the uncertainty that followed the earlier proposals. “After 2013, people started cutting down trees as they feared they would not be able to use their land later. Farmlands were abandoned, and land prices fell. Apprehensions about the notification have done more damage here than anything else,” he says.

A landscape built by migration

The history of these settlements in the ghats region goes back to several generations.

The erstwhile Travancore administration’s Grow More Food campaign in the early 1940s encouraged migration to the high ranges. Families moved into the hills for farming. Over time, human habitations emerged and transformed large swathes of the mountains into agricultural landscapes.

Joseph Thomas, 85, a farmer from Udayagiri, near Kattappana, in Idukki has spent about six decades farming in the high ranges. His parents migrated from Kottayam to Idukki nearly 80 years ago.

For him, the present debate is not simply about environmental regulation but about the future of communities that have lived here for generations.

“If such regulations are brought in, people will eventually be forced to leave their land,” he fears. Idukki, where 51 villages figure in the latest draft, has emerged as the epicentre of protests as during the times of the Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel report. All the grama sabhas passed resolutions urging the Union and the State go-



Inclusion of a holding in the ESA will take the villages out of the State’s jurisdiction and place them with the Central regime, and residents will then be forced to seek Central clearance for almost every activity

ALEX OZHUKAYIL
Chairperson of Kerala Independent Farmers Association

vernments to exclude their villages from the regime.

Melukavu panchayat president Bincy Tomy says the issue has already affected access to loans and land transactions. It has also impacted the marriage prospects of youngsters of the region, she points out.

Anil Sebastian, president of the Rubber Producers’ Society at Edamaruku in Kottayam, questions the ecological rationale for including Melukavu in ESA. The nearest forests, he says, are about 30 km to the north and 50 km to the south.

Church in the forefront

The Idukki Diocese of the Syro-Malabar Church has been at the forefront of the anti-ESA agitation since 2013. The High Range Samrakshana Samiti, under the patronage of the diocese, organised a series of protests across the high ranges. The Church continues to argue that human settlements and agricultural land should be kept outside the ESA.

“Human habitations and farmlands shall be fully excluded. Designating 51 villages as ESAs will disrupt normal life across the district. The Church supports the protests as the issue threatens the survival of the local population,” says Fr. Jins Karakkatt, director of the Idukki Diocese Media Commission. The present anxiety is rooted in a decade-old debate over how the Western Ghats should be protected.

The concerns extend beyond the Church and its affiliates. Alex Ozhukayil, chairperson of the Kerala Independent Farmers Association, sees the ESA proposal as creating two categories of residents, those who live in the ESAs and outside.

“The inclusion of a holding in the ESA will take the villages out of the jurisdiction of the

State Revenue department and place them with the Central regime, and residents would then be forced to seek Central clearance for almost every activity. Eventually, the residents will have to vacate the region,” Alex fears.

The issue also reshaped district politics. In the 2014 Lok Sabha election, Joyce George, legal adviser to the Samiti and a Left Democratic Front (LDF)-backed Independent, won the Idukki seat, which was long considered a Congress citadel.

From Gadgil to Kasturirangan

The root of the dispute lies in the Madhav Gadgil-led Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel report, which proposed a comprehensive zonation of the ghats based on ecological sensitivity.

In the high ranges, however, the report generated fears that agriculture and development would be restricted and that existing settlements could eventually face displacement.

Later, the Centre appointed a High-Level Working Group (HLWG) led by K. Kasturirangan to review the Gadgil recommendations. The HLWG, according to environmentalists, watered down the restrictions.

The first draft notification, based on the HLWG report and issued on March 10, 2014, proposed 123 revenue villages in Keralam, mainly in Idukki and Wayanad, as ESAs. But protests prevented the final notification from being issued, and six more draft notifications followed without resolving the dispute.

Subsequently, the State government-appointed Oommen V. Oommen committee recommended that inhabited areas, plantations and agricultural lands be excluded from the ESA through physical verification and field surveys. It also proposed re-fixing the ecologically sensitive areas using cadastral maps approved by the Kerala State Biodiversity Board. Those recommendations became the basis of Keralam’s position in subsequent negotiations with the Centre.

The arguments from conservationists are markedly different from those heard in the high range settlements. N. Badusha, president of the Wayanad Prakruthi Samrakshana Samiti, says some interest groups are stoking unnecessary fears with ulterior motives.

“The apprehensions that there will be restrictions on building houses and digging wells in the ESAs are baseless political propaganda pushed by vested interest groups,” he says.

“We have a host of laws, including the Forest

Act and the Wildlife Protection Act, to protect forests. So it is pointless to classify forest areas as ESAs to protect forests,” Badusha adds.

V.S. Vijayan, a member of the Gadgil panel, says the panel was misunderstood in the high ranges. “The report only recommended a shift to organic farming. It never opposed farming. It opposed the pollution of water resources through chemical pesticides and called for non-polluting industries. There were no restrictions on local infrastructure development,” he says.

Vijayan says the panel’s approach was to give local communities a decisive role in determining how development should proceed in ecologically sensitive landscapes rather than impose a blanket ban on local activity.

Oommen also feels that the latest proposal is far removed from the version feared by high range residents.

“The latest draft notification has excluded farmlands and plantations from the ESAs. What is the interest of the high range communities in opposing the protection of fragile rocky land that is not owned by them?” he wonders.

Govt. seeks smaller ESAs

The State government will reiterate that its ESAs shall be limited to 8,590.69 sq km across 98 villages, excluding human habitations and agricultural areas. It wants the ecologically sensitive areas to be confined to forests and leased forest plantations. The demand also reflects a position taken by successive State governments, cutting across the political divide.

The State further argues that inhabited and cultivated landscapes should not be treated in the same manner as forests and other ecologically fragile areas. For residents, the distinction is critical because their houses, farms and livelihoods are embedded in the same landscape that conservation policy seeks to protect.

Residents and farmers’ organisations fear that an ESA designation could restrict them from using or developing their land. However, conservationists and those involved in framing the proposals argue that the notification is primarily intended to regulate activities that can damage fragile ecosystems.

For conservationists, the central issue is whether human activity in the Western Ghats can continue without weakening ecological safeguards. And that disagreement has been simmering for more than a decade of committees, consultations and draft notifications.

UNESCO status

The farmers’ organisations have also linked the ESA debate to the Western Ghats’ UNESCO World Heritage status.

Mathew Varghese, State vice-president of the All India Kisan Sabha, the Communist Party of India’s (CPI) farmers’ wing, has demanded that the Western Ghats be excluded from the UNESCO World Heritage Site status, which demands more stringent conservation efforts.

“However, the UNESCO guidelines also say that if a project disrupts the livelihood or daily life of the local population, that area must be excluded,” he says.

Back in Randattumoonni, the hilly hamlet, the rain has begun to ease. Water rushes down the slopes towards the streams below, eventually joining the Meenachil river.

The same hills are viewed in two different ways: as a fragile ecological system that requires protection, and as a lived landscape of farms, homes and communities built over generations.

For people like Tashkent, the question is not whether the hills need protection. It is whether that ESA regime can accommodate the people who have made the hills their home.



Airing dissent: Bincy Tomy, president of Melukavu panchayat in Kottayam, speaks about the Ecologically Sensitive Area issue at a Kudumbashree gathering at Edamaruku. VISHNU PRATHAP

TELANGANA



The premises of Hyderabad's iconic Shanti Theatre in Narayanguda now serves as a godown after the single-screen cinema shut down; (below) movie buffs queue up at the ticket counter of Sandhya Theatre in RTC Crossroads, for Telugu release *Lenin*. RAMAKRISHNA G. & SIDDHANT THAKUR

Changing culture of movie-watching

From iconic single screens to multiplexes, streaming platforms and movies watched at home, Hyderabad's cinema culture has changed dramatically over the years. Theatres that once anchored neighbourhoods have shut, others have reinvented themselves, and the meaning of 'going to the movies' has shifted. Yet the appetite for films and the pull of a shared big-screen experience remains, writes **Naveen Kumar**

The projector at Shanti 70MM in Hyderabad's Narayanguda has been silent for six years, but cinema has not entirely left the building. This Ganesh Chaturthi, rows of idols stood where moviegoers once queued for tickets, while the theatre's familiar facade looked down on a space that had once seen giant cut-outs, packed houses and whistles for star entrances.

Opened in 1969, Shanti became one of Hyderabad's best-known single screens. N.T. Rama Rao's *Daana Veera Soora Karna* ran there for 250 days in 1977. But after COVID-19 shut cinemas in 2020, Shanti never reopened. The management decided to close it permanently and use the premises as a godown.

Its fate captures a larger shift in Hyderabad's cinema culture. The number of single screens has dwindled, multiplexes have changed the experience and OTT has brought films home, but the appetite for the big screen remains. *The Paradise* starring Nani recently opened to packed houses, with giant cut-outs positioned outside single screens across the city. The buildings and the business of cinema may be changing, but the craze for going to the movies has proved harder to kill. During the Ganesh immersion rush, people even manoeuvred through trucks carrying idols around Tank Bund to reach Prasads theatre for the 8 a.m. show.

Just outside Shanti, 44-year-old Suresh runs a tea and cigarette kiosk. His first film there was *Ik-kada Abbai Akkada Ammayi* in 1996. "We could watch the movie and have snacks and wrap up our evening for ₹50. The ticket cost ₹10 and a soft drink less than ₹10 back then," he recalls.

Today, he has stopped going to theatres. "Now you cannot think of spending anything less than ₹2,000 for a movie at a multiplex, if you go with family. I have stopped going to the theatres altogether. I rely on OTT and cable TV," he says.

He also remembers the informal circuit around the old theatres: Shanti's 2.45 p.m. booking window was a second chance for those who missed the 1.45 p.m. booking at Sandhya at RTC Crossroads. "Take a bus from there and you land here," he says.

There was a time when watching a film meant planning an outing around a place. Viewers chose a theatre, reached there, joined a queue and hoped tickets were available. The coloured paper ticket, posters outside, interval snacks, whistles and applause were all part of the experience.

When theatres were landmarks
Writer and comedian Deepak Karamungikar, who has watched films since he was four, recalls watching Telugu films with his uncle and even bunking college to watch as many as 100 films in each of his two years of Intermediate. A balcony ticket cost ₹6, or ₹8 at most, at that time.

The experience had its own rituals: dress-circle and front-row seats, soft drinks carried through the auditorium, unbranded potato chips

You cannot think of spending anything less than ₹2,000 for a movie at a multiplex, if you go with family. I've stopped going to the theatres altogether. I rely on OTT and cable TV.
SURESH,
Tea stall owner

and ushers guiding viewers to their seats with torchlight.

Through the 1970s, 1980s and 1990s, Hyderabad's cinema map was dotted with landmarks – Sangeet, Anand, Tivoli, Natraj, Ajanta, Raghavendra, Odeon, Sudarshan, Sandhya, Vimal and Gokul. Some became so embedded in the city that their names outlived the theatres. Nearly two decades after Sangeet shut, the crossroads is still known as Sangeet Junction.

But what made these theatres part of the city was also the people who filled them. Inside a dark auditorium, a businessman could sit beside a schoolteacher, a government employee could laugh alongside a factory worker, and a college student could whistle at a hero's entrance with somebody twice his age. For two or three hours, everyone was simply an audience.

That shared experience could alter a film. A comedy became funnier in a packed hall, a hero's entrance could bring hundreds to their feet and a song could trigger applause before it had properly begun. The film was the same, but every audience could make it feel different.

Brand strategist Ashish Chowdhury remembers Sangeet and Anand, along with Skyline in Himayatnagar and Sensation in Lakdikapul, as prominent theatres of the early 1990s. Maheshwari Parameshwari had an added attraction: an escalator. When he watched *Refugee* there in 2000, he recalls going up and down it "at least 10 times".

Years later, while watching *Avengers* in Benga-

luru in 2012, Chowdhury found former India cricketer Rahul Dravid sitting beside him. It was a chance encounter that neatly captured the cinema hall's ability to put strangers from different lives in the same row.

When cinema moved into a mall
Multiplexes changed not just the number of screens but the architecture of movie-going itself. Karamungikar remembers visiting Prasads when it opened in 2003 and being struck by an 8.45 a.m. show, unusual in a city used to 11 a.m., 2 p.m., 6 p.m. and 9 p.m. screenings.

More importantly, the cinema had become part of a larger outing. Multiplexes offered multiple films and timings under one roof, along with better seating, air-conditioning, sound, projection, parking and food. "We were unaware of the concept of a place where we can do much more than just watch a movie," Karamungikar says, describing Prasads as a cornerstone in the shift in Hyderabad's movie culture.

Chowdhury also points to the greater accessibility multiplexes offered differently-abled viewers. "I think, for once, a differently abled person could visit a theatre and experience the large screen," he adds.

There were around 3,600 single-screen theatres in the two Telugu States at their peak, the highest in India. Now there are around 1,600.
M. VIJAYENDER REDDY,
President, Telangana Telugu Exhibitors Association

Technology has continued to reshape the movie-going experience, with Hyderabad now home to large-format screens, LED projection and Dolby-equipped auditoriums.

But the new experience also changed the economics. Karamungikar cites ticket and food costs among the reasons audiences moved towards OTT and, in some cases, piracy.

For theatre owners, the calculation is more fundamental: how much can a property earn by showing films, and how much could it earn doing something else?

Across Hyderabad, former cinemas illustrate the answer. Usha Mayuri at RTC Crossroads was replaced by a petrol pump while Galaxy Theatre at Tolichowki gave way to a commercial estate. Krishna Talkies in the Old City was reported to

have become a mall while Shama Talkies at Jahanuma shut after nearly four decades, with its owner saying the family planned a function hall in its place.

M. Vijayender Reddy, president of the Telangana Telugu Exhibitors Association and joint secretary of the Telugu Film Chamber, has watched the business change for nearly five decades. He opened Venkateshwara theatre in 1976 and recalls how revenue arrangements, film hiring, taxation and ticketing systems evolved.

"It was a hit-and-miss risk," he says of the earlier hire system, in which exhibitors took films at their own risk.

The larger change is visible in the numbers. "There were around 3,600 single-screen theatres in the two Telugu States at their peak, the highest in India. Now there are around 1,600," he says. By his estimate, about 2,000 have either shut or their properties have been taken over for other businesses.

For exhibitors, the equation ultimately remains simple: "The number of tickets sold decides the fate," Reddy says. As footfall declines, the land beneath a theatre can make better business sense than the screen inside it.

When the cinema came home
As theatres found new uses, films found a new home.

OTT platforms were already growing before 2020, but the COVID-19 lockdown pushed streaming into the centre of household entertainment. There was no need to cross the city, find parking or arrange an evening around a showtime. A film could be paused for dinner, resumed the next morning or abandoned halfway.

The economics strengthened the appeal. A household can spend roughly ₹650 to ₹1,500 on subscriptions for a month and access a vast catalogue, while a family outing for a major film can cross ₹2,000 after tickets, transport and food. The choice is no longer between one movie ticket and one streaming subscription, but between one evening of entertainment and a month of it.

Karamungikar says OTT has also opened opportunities for creators, and his own viewing has shifted towards television shows. Yet he remains emphatic: "Movies belong in a theatre." For him, OTT is better suited for rewatches or films missed in theatres. The theatre has moved from being the default destination for a film to a place that must offer a reason to leave home.

Spectacle remains one reason. Big action films, visual productions, major star releases and films built around sound and scale can still turn a screening into an event. First-day shows still draw fans, and a horror film can be more frightening when an entire room jumps together. For other films, "I will wait for the OTT release" has become routine. Audiences have not necessarily abandoned cinema; they have become more selective about which films deserve the trip.

Yet the theatre offers something streaming cannot easily reproduce: collective attention. At home, a film competes with messages, chores and notifications. In a dark auditorium, two or three hours belong to one story.

Chowdhury sees another version of collective viewing emerging in smaller community spaces, where groups gather for older, obscure or non-mainstream films. He recalls watching *Whiplash* (2014) with about 20 people at one such screening.

Perhaps that is the paradox of Hyderabad's changing relationship with cinema. The city has never had more ways to watch a film, even as some of the buildings that once existed solely for hundreds of people to watch one together have disappeared or found entirely different lives. But the desire to watch together has not vanished. It has simply moved: from the neighbourhood single screen to the multiplex, from the multiplex to the living room, and now, in some cases, into smaller rooms where people still choose to watch together.



INBRIEF



‘No commitment made to unions on 5-day work week’

Rejecting claims of bank employee unions regarding a commitment to implement a five-day work week, government sources said there was no commitment on the issue from the Finance Ministry. Bank employee unions under the United Forum of Bank Unions have announced a three-day strike from September 28 to press for their demands, including a five-day work week. The strike, if it materialises, would coincide with the banking sector's half-yearly close. PTI

India should allow exchanges to list on own platform: NSE

India's markets regulator should reconsider allowing exchanges to list on their own platforms, NSE Chairman Srinivas Injeti said on Friday, a day after the bourse operator debuted on rival BSE at a valuation of about \$47 billion. SEBI debated allowing self-listing in 2015 but rejected the idea over potential conflicts of interest, requiring their shares to trade on rival bourses. However, self-listing is permitted in several major global markets. REUTERS

TRAI launches digital rating platform for properties

The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) on Friday launched an integrated Digital Connectivity Rating (DCR) platform and a dedicated mobile app to assess and certify in-building mobile and internet connectivity across residential, commercial, and government properties. The platform is designed to enable prospective buyers and tenants to evaluate digital readiness prior to purchasing or leasing. PTI

AI-led phone price hikes persist, hitting Indian customers

A series of price hikes has put budget phones out of reach for many who choose to wait for festival discounts or settle for 'less-powerful' devices

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

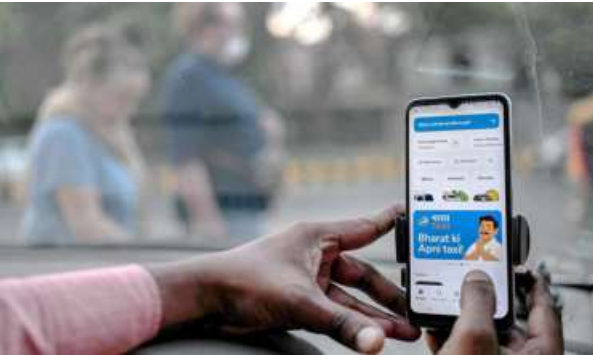
As smartphone prices increase due to a spike in demand for memory chips by AI companies and data centres, phone retailers have seen customer base dry up in a significant way.

“This is the first time I’m seeing phone prices increase, and continue increasing relentlessly, in the last 20 years,” said Vivek Singh, 42, a phone retailer in south Delhi, who has been in the business for decades. “I have 10 or 15 people coming into the shop each day, and only one or two buy a phone,” he said. Since February, phone makers have been sending retailers price hike notifications that have been progressively growing.

The Hindu obtained such notifications from Vivo, Samsung, Realme, Oppo, Nothing, Poco, and Xiaomi from the All India Mobile Retailers Association (AIMRA).

Price hikes have ranged from ₹1,000 to ₹5,000, but that is only the latest tranche. “People ask me for ₹10,000 phones, but there is no such thing any more,” Mr. Singh rued, noting that some budget handsets’ prices have more than doubled.

The results of these



Pocket unfriendly: Price hikes have ranged from ₹1,000 to ₹5,000, but that is only the latest tranche. AFP

hikes have not been completely doom and gloom just yet, at least not yet.

Kailash Lakhyani, AIMRA's founder chairman, told The Hindu that retailers were beginning to see better prices for pre-owned phones they got during trade-in purchases, and that retailers who had already purchased stock at an old dealer price were benefiting from a higher margin at newer prices.

A review of price hike notifications showed that some retailers saw their margins jump from 3.85% to over 14% for some Samsung phones. “60% of phones are being purchased overall,” Mr. Lakhyani claimed. “20% of customers are settling for less powerful phones, or buying second hand, and the 20% of customers below that are waiting for the festival season hoping for

discounts,” he added. “There’s also a rumour of a GST cut for smartphones, so some customers are waiting for that,” he said. The GST for smartphones stands at 18%. But this situation may worsen. “We have been in touch with phone companies, and they say this situation may go on till 2028 or even 2030,” Mr. Lakhyani said. “Next year also there will be hikes, but it may be more like a plane rather than a rocket [like this year was],” he added.

The phenomenon is global, as the memory chip crunch created by AI demand has hit electronics supply chains across the board. “Global sub-\$200 smartphone shipments are forecast to fall -40% between 2025 and 2030,” Counterpoint Research, a smartphone sales analyst firm, said on Thursday.

Economy resilient with downside risks from West Asia conflict: RBI bulletin

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI), in its monthly bulletin released late on Friday, stated that the Indian economy had stayed resilient despite global uncertainties rising from the West Asia crisis.

“The escalation of conflict in West Asia in September has led to a sharp increase in crude oil prices, reigniting concerns of a further disruption in global supply chains and build-up of inflationary pressures,” the RBI stated.

Pressure on finances

“Alongside, the rise in sovereign yields in some of the major advanced economies has put pressure on government finances. Despite such a challenging global environment, the Indian economy recorded a strong GDP growth in Q1:2026-27,” it said.

“High-frequency indicators through August reflected sustained demand with segments of industry and services sectors displaying resilience,” the RBI added in the bulletin.

The central bank further flagged inflationary tendencies in the economy transmitting as crude prices have begun increasing again. “Headline CPI inflation picked up in August 2026. Core inflation excluding precious metals has also increased from ultra-low levels of recent



The central bank flagged inflationary tendencies in the Indian economy.

months,” the RBI said.

Commenting on the foreign exchange reserves, the regulator said that the special deposit scheme for non-resident Indians (NRIs) led to a record high reserve position of \$766 billion as of September 18, 2026.

“The reserves provided cover for 11.2 months of goods imports [as on September 18] and more than 100% of the external debt outstanding as at end March 2026,” the RBI stated in the bulletin.

FCNR B flows also led to an increase in system liquidity, which has resulted in quickening deposit growth potentially supporting the ongoing credit growth cycle. On the external front, the RBI said that India's financial and external sectors drew strength from the real economy, despite geopolitical tensions and weather-related uncertainties are acting as key downside risks.

Power plants may blend imported coal with domestic supplies

Reuters
NEW DELHI

India is considering telling power plants to blend imported coal with domestic supplies for the first time since 2024, three government sources said, to ease a supply crunch that has pushed monthly spot power prices to their highest since 2022.

Higher global coal demand and rising freight costs are set to make imports costlier, as Indonesian prices are up about a fifth since May while Russian prices are 14% higher and South African rates are up 19%, traders say.

5% blending

Under the plan being discussed by the officials of the power ministry, thermal power plants would have to blend up to 5% imported coal with domestic coal, said the sources, who are directly aware of the matter.

The plan represents a sharp reversal in New Delhi's drive to boost domestic coal production and curb imports, which helped prune overseas supplies over the past two years.

Most of India's coal-fired power plants rely primarily on domestic coal, but can blend up to 15% imported coal.

Indian coal imports are already at a 15-month high.

The government's previous coal-blending directives ran from December 2021 to March 2024.

JSW One Platforms files draft for ₹3,054-cr. IPO

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

JSW One Platforms Ltd., a technology-enabled B2B platform for manufacturing and construction, filed draft papers with market regulator SEBI to raise up to ₹3,054 crore through an initial public offering (IPO).

The proposed IPO comprises fresh issue of equity shares worth up to ₹1,300 crore and an Offer for Sale (OFS) of shares worth up to ₹1,754.01 crore, as per draft red herring prospectus.

The firm plans to use net proceeds from fresh issue to invest ₹125 crore in JSW One Distribution Ltd., ₹500 crore in JSW One Finance Ltd. and up to ₹350 crore for technology and platform development. The balance will be for general corporate purposes.

Driving on expensive fuel



Slow burn: Truck drivers take part in a go-slow convoy to protest against rising fuel prices at Lordelo, near Pacos de Ferreira, northern Portugal on Friday. AFP

‘Over 10 bn autonomous agents to clog public service’

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

More than 10 billion autonomous agents created by people, firms and governments will clog public services by the end of 2030, forecast Gartner, among its top predictions across three categories: robots everywhere, cost to value and unknown unknowns.

As per Gartner, Agentic AI will significantly raise demand for public services by enabling autonomous agents to spot opportunities, determine eligibility and submit requests on behalf of users with minimal human effort. This surge in applications, claims and transactions will put pressure on government systems and need stronger approaches to identity, trust and accountability.

Govt. ‘weighs’ IDBI strategic sale bids

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The government is evaluating financial bids for strategic stake sale in IDBI Bank with the process moving at a steady pace, government sources said.

In July, billionaire investor Prem Watsa-backed Fairfax Financial Holdings and Dubai-based Emirates NBD put in revised bids to buy 60.72% in IDBI Bank, sources had earlier said.

Both the bidders have experience in the Indian banking sector with Dubai-based Emirates NBD acquiring majority stake in RBL Bank earlier this year and Fairfax Financial holding a 40% stake in the private-sector CSB Bank.

Security clearance

The bidders already have security clearance from Ministry of Home Affairs



Government and LIC are looking to sell 60.72% stake.

(MHA) and ‘Fit and Proper’ assessment from the Reserve Bank of India.

This is the second time interested bidders have put in bids for buying stake in IDBI Bank, in which the Centre and Life Insurance Corporation together are looking to sell 60.72%.

Currently, the government and State-owned LIC together hold 94.71% in IDBI Bank. The government owns 45.48% and LIC 49.24% in the lender.

Tesla drives growth with sixth India Experience Centre in Tamil Nadu

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tesla India on Friday opened its sixth Experience Centre in the country here, expanding retail and after-sales presence in Tamil Nadu.

The firm also started service and body-shop operations here taking the network in India to eight locations.

“We already have experience centers in Mumbai, Gurugram, Delhi, Hyderabad, Bangalore and now, we are in Chennai,” said Sharad Agarwal, Tesla India's head.



Going global: The experience centre would offer local consultation, test drives and vehicle delivery support. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Tesla said the Chennai Experience Centre would provide local consultation, test drives and vehicle delivery support. The company has also made available

Tesla-approved collision centre and service capabilities at Poonamallee, providing access to genuine Tesla parts, trained technicians, software-aware diag-

nostics and collision repair. Tesla offers Model Y Premium Rear-Wheel Drive at ₹50.89 lakh with a ‘range of up to 500 km.’

The three-row, six-seat Model YL starts at ₹61.99 lakh with a ‘range of up to 681 km.’ Tesla vehicles have no prescribed maintenance schedule, he claimed. Over 70% problems can be resolved remotely. Tesla also introduced Grok AI in its cars.

“With Grok AI, you can control a lot of features inside the car. You no longer have to touch and find the features. You sit and give the command,” he said.

India’s Zee escalates copyright fight against Reliance-Disney’s JioStar

Reuters
NEW DELHI

India's Zee Entertainment asked the Delhi High Court to initiate contempt proceedings against Reliance-Disney joint venture JioStar, alleging it continued to use copyrighted content despite a court injunction, a legal filing shows.

The filing, dated September 21, escalates an ongoing copyright dispute between the companies. Zee alleges JioStar is guilty of “wilful disobedience” because it continued using Zee's music and songs in programmes broadcast on



JioStar earlier said infringements were ‘unintentional.’

its platforms despite court order barring such use.

JioStar, formed from the \$8.5 billion merger of Reliance and Disney's Indian media assets in 2024, de-

clined to comment. Zee did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

The copyright case was heard on Friday. A source aware of the details of court hearing told Reuters the Delhi High Court asked JioStar for a response to Zee's latest allegations and the case will be heard next in December.

The lawsuit began in April when Zee sought \$3 million in damages, citing 50 alleged copyright violations involving content from its music division.

In May, the Delhi High Court ordered JioStar not

to “use, publish, broadcast, stream, upload” any of Zee's licensed works.

JioStar's lawyers have previously told the court the alleged infringements were “unintentional” and “purely residual in nature”. The company said in May that it had removed a substantial volume of Zee content following the expiry of licensing agreements.

In its latest filing, Zee cited six instances between May and July that it said showed the continued use of its copyrighted works by JioStar. JioStar is “illegally and actively exploiting” the works, Zee said.

UNITED NATIONS
Nepal's leader says recent floods serve as a 'warning to the world'



Nepal's Prime Minister Balendra Shah scolded fellow world leaders on Thursday, saying the nation's recent deadly flood reminds a warming world that climate change keeps hurting people who didn't cause the crisis but now need help. The August disaster "was not just a local tragedy. It was a warning to the world," he said. AP

UNITED NATIONS
UN Security Council condemns Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia



The United Nations Security Council condemned on Friday escalating attacks on Saudi Arabia by Yemeni Houthi militants in a rare show of unity from the UN's top body. "The members of the Security Council condemned, in the strongest terms, continued Houthi attacks against the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia," it said. AFP

WASHINGTON
Xi says he expects to see Trump again after he wraps up U.S. visit



Chinese President Xi Jinping wrapped up his state visit to Washington on Friday by announcing that he expects to meet President Donald Trump two more times before the end of the year, doubling the number of face-to-face discussions between the leaders of the world's two largest economies in 2026. AP

NEW YORK
Mamdani puts Jews in danger by spreading lies, says Netanyahu



Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu accused Mayor Zohran Mamdani of endangering Jewish New Yorkers with his criticism of Israel's military actions in Gaza, saying during a speech at the UN on Thursday that the mayor has spread lies about Israel. He also called Mr. Mamdani "the anti-Semitic mayor of New York". AP

Iran's Araghchi suggests a deal to reopen Strait of Hormuz in 7 days

The offer is contingent on the U.S. lifting its naval blockade, waiving sanctions on Iranian oil sales, and observing a ceasefire; President Pezeshkian says Iran does not want to continue fighting and that 'it is America that must choose' to end the war

Associated Press
NEW YORK

Iran has offered to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and resume talks on its nuclear programme in seven days if the United States lifts its naval blockade, waives sanctions on Iranian oil sales and observes a ceasefire that would include Lebanon. Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi detailed the proposal in a private gathering on Thursday on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in New York, according to one attendee. Trita Parsi, executive vice-president of the Quincy Institute think tank,



Abbas Araghchi and other delegates attend the 81st United Nations General Assembly in New York City on Wednesday. REUTERS

who attended, said Mr. Araghchi suggested that a speedy agreement would help U.S. President Donald Trump ahead of November's midterm elections. There was no immediate comment from Iran's UN mission or other Iranian officials. The proposal strongly resembles the so-called Memorandum of Understanding reached in June,

but with an accelerated timetable. The earlier agreement, which had called for a 60-day interim period, quickly collapsed as Iran resumed attacks on shipping in the strait. Mr. Trump has said he is in no rush to reach a deal, even as high oil prices fuel inflation and exacerbate cost of living concerns. On the Iranian side, there are questions as to whether the hard-liners who dominate the security forces will accept compromises championed by relative moderates, like President Masoud Pezeshkian. Meanwhile, Mr. Pezeshkian, in a U.S. television interview aired on Thursday, said that it is for the United

States to choose whether to end its war in Iran as Tehran does not wish to continue fighting. He took a defiant stand at the UN, for which he travelled to New York, telling the world that Iran would not "bend at the knee" to Washington – even as Mr. Trump acknowledged ongoing U.S.-Iran talks. "When we can resolve issues through dialogue, we shouldn't resort to killing one another. But with the instigations conducted by Israel, they have imposed this war on us," he said on Fox News. "But we do not wish to continue. It's America that must choose whether it wants to end this or not."

Pak. claims it killed several Afghan Taliban fighters

Press Trust of India
ISLAMABAD

Pakistani security forces killed several Afghan Taliban fighters after they allegedly attempted to enter Pakistan and opened hostilities along the border in Balochistan province, state-run media reported on Friday. The development comes after Pakistan conducted aerial and drone strikes on 10 locations in Afghanistan on Thursday. Afghanistan's Taliban regime said the strikes killed four civilians. The state-run Associated Press of Pakistan, citing security sources, said Afghan Taliban fighters attempted to enter Pakistani territory in Balochistan's Gulistan sector on Thursday and carry out an "act of aggression". Pakistani forces retaliated, killing several Afghan Taliban fighters, the report said, adding that intermittent exchanges of fire continued after midnight. However, the claims about the casualties and the circumstances leading to the latest border clash could not be independently verified. There was no immediate detailed statement from the Afghan Taliban



Taliban security personnel inspect the site after Pakistani air strike struck Gurbuz district in Afghanistan on Thursday. AFP

on the Gulistan clash. Information Minister Attaullah Tarar said the strikes on Thursday were carried out after drones entered Pakistan from Afghan territory on Wednesday. Mr. Tarar described the alleged drone incursion as a "blatant violation of Pakistan's sovereignty and territorial integrity" and a "grave act of aggression".

Sri Lanka extends tenure of judges despite protests

Agence France-Presse
COLOMBO

Sri Lanka's government voted on Friday to increase the mandatory retirement age of all judges by two years as part of reforms opposed in Parliament and by the influential bar association. President Anura Kumara Disسانayake unveiled two Bills last month as part of wider judicial reforms he said are needed to reduce legal delays in hundreds of thousands of cases. The Bills also seek to increase the number of courthouses, create new appellate courts outside the capital and recruit additional magistrates and staff to speed up trials, as well as the recruitment of 10,000 police officers. Opposition legislators wore black in protest



Anura Kumara Disسانayake

against the two Bills before Friday's vote. Raising the retirement age of judges required a two-thirds majority in Parliament in order to amend the Constitution, and 158 MPs in the 225-seat Assembly voted in favour. The two-year extension will now apply to 411 judges in Sri Lanka. Opposition Leader Sajith Premadasa accused the government of turning the judiciary into a pawn of the executive.

"Attempting to control our country's noble, free and independent judiciary through a constitutional conspiracy is a shameless and despicable act," Mr. Premadasa told Parliament. He led thousands of supporters in a protest outside Parliament at the start of two days of debate on Thursday. Mr. Disسانayake has argued that the reforms are necessary to clear a backlog of 1.1 million cases. Criminal proceedings usually take more than 17 years in Sri Lanka, while civil cases can take generations to conclude. The influential Bar Association of Sri Lanka also opposed the Bills and called for a national referendum. However, the Supreme Court ruled that a two-thirds majority in Parliament was sufficient.

Locked and loaded



Naval drill: Turkish Navy's UH-60 Black Hawk with T129 ATAK participate in a ceremonial parade during the Denizkurdu-1/2026 Exercise in the Eastern Mediterranean, off the coast of Aksaz, at Marmaris in Mugla, on Thursday. AFP

Imran's party postpones planned rally to October 4

Reuters
ISLAMABAD

Jailed former Prime Minister Imran Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf party has postponed a planned long march from Peshawar to Islamabad until October 4, the Chief Minister of the PTI-ruled Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, Sohail Afridi, told presspersons on Friday. PTI had planned to begin the march on September 27 to press for the release of Mr. Khan, who has been in jail since 2023. Earlier this week, Pakistan curbed access to its capital, Islamabad, by blocking major highways with shipping containers and deploying tens of thousands of security forces, ahead of the planned march.

Philippines accuses China of obstructing a resupply mission

Reuters
MANILA

The Philippine Coast Guard (PCG) accused China on Friday of obstructing a resupply mission to troops on board a grounded Second World War-era warship in the South China Sea, saying dangerous manoeuvres by Chinese vessels "put Filipino personnel at risk" and prevented the mission from being completed. "There was no collision, and no one was injured,

but the dangerous manoeuvres of the China Coast Guard created a serious risk of collision," said Jay Tarriela, a PCG spokesperson on South China Sea issues. The PCG said China's actions were inconsistent with international law. China Coast Guard spokesperson Jiang Lue said the Philippines had ignored Beijing's warnings when it sent the resupply vessel to the grounded warship, prompting "on-site monitoring" and verbal warnings by China.

Final results of Russia's vote give record high parliament seats to Kremlin party

Associated Press
MOSCOW

Full results released on Friday from Russia's first wartime parliamentary election showed that the tightly orchestrated vote had further cemented the Kremlin's overwhelming political control of the country. United Russia, the main Kremlin party, will get more than three-fourths of the seats in the State Duma, a record high, according to returns released by the Central Election Commission.



A screen displays the final results of Russia's parliamentary election at the headquarters of the Election Commission in Moscow. REUTERS

Virtually any genuine Opposition parties or candidates were excluded from running in the Sep-

tember 18-20 election. A massive state media campaign and tight control over the voting process al-

lowed the Kremlin to strengthen its political dominance despite Russia's economic troubles and long-range Ukrainian drone attacks. Election commission chief Ella Pamfilova said United Russia got 349 out of 450 seats in the State Duma, the lower chamber. Several smaller parties representing the "systemic Opposition" that vote in line with the Kremlin on all key issues won 97 seats, and the remaining four seats were filled by regional officials who ran without a party affiliation.

Trump made 'final decision' to give Kyiv Patriots: Zelenskyy

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Friday said U.S. President Donald Trump told him he would allow Ukraine to produce advanced Patriot air defence missiles, after a series of reversals on the issue. Kyiv is facing a shortage of the missiles, needed to counter Russia's increasing drone and missile attacks on the country, the latest of which killed a 14-year-

old boy in the capital on Friday. Mr. Zelenskyy during his latest visit to the U.S. this week renewed calls for air defence support, and for the Patriots, which remain the only system reliably able to counter Russia's powerful ballistic missiles. "At our last meeting, President Trump emphasised to me that yes, I have made a final decision. Ukraine will receive licences for the production of Patriot missiles," Mr. Zelenskyy said.



Global message: Pope Leo XIV with French President Emmanuel Macron at the Elysee Palace on Friday. AP

Pope shares views on AI, secularism, war in French visit

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Pope Leo XIV on Friday warned against losing humanity in a “paradise of machines”, after church bells rang and thousands gathered to welcome him to France amid worldwide concern over the dangers of artificial intelligence.

“If we are to avoid losing our humanity amid a paradise of machines invading and conditioning our daily lives, there is an urgent need for education in ethical discernment,” Mr. Leo said after President Emmanuel Macron welcomed him to the Presidential palace, on the first of four days in the country.

The pope also stressed that “authentic secular-ity” should not exclude religion. “It consists not in excluding religion from the public sphere or from education, but in striving to ensure that the state and religious institutions maintain dialogue and join forces in the service of the common good”.

Politicians have in recent years invoked France’s brand of secularism to justify bans on religious symbols including Muslim women’s attire in public spaces and schools.

After France passed legislation in June granting some adult patients the right to assisted dying, the first U.S. pontiff said he was concerned by trends “that risk turning science and technology into profit-driven ventures promoting genetic manipulation, surrogacy, or trade in human organs”.

The pope urged France to remain a “tireless champion of peace” worldwide, as Russia’s invasion of Ukraine drags into its fifth year. “I’m travelling to France as a follower of Jesus Christ wanting to proclaim peace, the peace of Christ throughout the world,” he said ahead of the visit.

Associated Press
WARSAW

When Poland stopped registering asylum applications from migrants entering from Belarus in March 2025, authorities presented it as a temporary emergency measure to counter what they saw as a push by Russia and its ally Belarus to destabilise the country by directing tens of thousands of migrants toward the European Union.

But the policy has remained in force for the past 18 months, and Poland is now urging the 27-nation bloc to allow temporary suspensions of asylum applications during episodes of “instrumentalised” mass migration elsewhere – a move that rights advocates warn could violate international law.

Since 2021, EU authorities have accused Belarusian President Alexander Lukashenko of weaponising migration by luring people to his country to find an easier entry point into the bloc than the more dangerous routes across the Mediterranean Sea.

New framework

The prospect of an EU-wide approach appeared to move closer on September 16, when European Commission President Ur-

sula von der Leyen announced that the EU executive branch would soon propose a new “European emergency response framework” for cases of “engineered and weaponised” mass migration.

The new emergency framework would allow for “flexibility” in applying standard migration procedures under specific circumstances and for a limited period of time, she said.

Ms. Von der Leyen didn’t specify what procedures would be made flexible. It’s unclear what form this proposed framework would take, whether it would need approval from the EU Parliament and EU leaders, and how soon it might come into practice.

But Poland’s Deputy Interior Minister in charge of migration, Maciej Dusz-zyk, celebrated the announcement as a sign that Europe was becoming interested in what he calls “the Polish solution.”

“We are happy that what we’ve been saying for a year, or a year and a half, is now becoming mainstream in the EU,” Mr. Duszczczyk said.

He said that the July border crisis in Ceuta, when more than 70,000 people crossed from Morocco into the Spanish enclave in Africa, “made the EU realise” that other countries can be affected by similar border crises as Poland.



Ground zero: File photo of European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk during their visit to the Polish-Belarus border, in Krynki, Poland. AP

Tineke Strik, a Dutch member of the European Parliament, said that she fears Ms. von der Leyen’s new emergency framework is indeed poised to take the Polish model EU-wide and legitimise the curtailing of asylum.

“If you normalise it, if you make it the default policy of all EU member states, you (the Poles) are not falling outside of the framework,” Ms. Strik said. “It simply has been legalised.”

“That would of course really undermine the core of the European and international asylum law – namely that people always must have the possibility to ask for asylum before they can be returned because

otherwise you don’t know what will happen to them,” she said.

‘Blow to human rights’
Michael O’Flaherty – the human rights commissioner for the Council of Europe, which is unrelated to the EU – said that the fact that the suspension of the right to asylum now appears in discussions at the EU level “worries” him because “it can very easily cross the line into a violation of international law.”

Critics say legalising the suspension of asylum would constitute a major blow to fundamental human rights, particularly the principle of non-refoulement, which bars countries from returning

people to places where they may face persecution.

The principle was enshrined in the postwar refugee protection system after Jews and others fleeing Nazi persecution were refused safe haven during Second World War.

Mr. Duszczczyk said that the suspension of the right to asylum in Poland is fully compatible with international law and that people in the most vulnerable categories – pregnant women, children or those facing persecution in Belarus – can still apply for asylum even under the current system.

But the Polish ombudsman and nongovernmental organisations assisting migrants on the border

contradict the Minister. “Visibly pregnant women might stand a chance, but in the case of sick people or teenagers who are minors, their arguments are typically undermined,” said Karolina Czerwinska from the Association for Legal Intervention, a Polish NGO offering legal aid to migrants.

Human rights groups said that Ms. Von der Leyen’s announcement came as a surprise, because the EU’s new Pact on Migration and Asylum, which took effect three months ago, already allowed countries faced with border crises to deviate from standard asylum procedures by extending deadlines for processing applications and holding migrants in detention for longer periods of time.

But Mr. Duszczczyk said that Ms. Von der Leyen’s announcement meant that the European Commission recognised the new pact was “not enough” and that “we need a new instrument in EU law which guarantees that sometimes we can suspend normal procedures and have a sort of state of emergency.”

The European Commission is expected to give more details during a summit of Interior Ministers on October 1, and discussions would continue during a European Council summit later that month.

Top court hands Trump a temporary win in collecting sensitive voter data

Reuters
WASHINGTON

In a key verdict, the U.S. Supreme Court on Friday lifted restrictions on a controversial federal voter database before November’s midterm elections, granting President Donald Trump a temporary win in his aggressive campaign against non-citizen voting.

Mr. Trump has pressed forward with an unprecedented push to obtain sensitive voter data, in a hunt for non-citizens illegally registered to vote, though there has been no evidence of widespread fraud of this kind.

The emergency order allows States, for now, to use the Department of Homeland Security programme, called Systematic Alien Verification for Entit-



Intense scrutiny: The U.S. President’s order directs creation of State citizen lists using data housed with federal government. AFP

lements (SAVE), in their efforts to verify the eligibility of voters on their rolls. But because existing law blocks most States from purging voters from their rolls within 90 days of an election, the immediate impact on the upcoming midterms is likely limited.

The court’s order puts on hold a federal judge’s

June ruling that had deemed the administration’s recently revamped version of SAVE illegal.

‘Violates privacy rights’
U.S. District Court Judge Sparkle L. Sooknnanan had blocked the use of the tool, saying it violated Americans’ privacy rights and could result in voters being

wrongly removed from the rolls. Mr. Trump for years has made false claims about voting fraud in the U.S., including his loss to Democrat Joe Biden in the 2020 presidential election.

Critics have said Mr. Trump’s drive is aimed at disenfranchising eligible Democratic-leaning voters.

“You can’t do mass disenfranchisement without a voter file,” said voting rights lawyer Marc Elias.

John Hill, a Washington-based lawyer, said Mr. Trump’s threat of prosecution of State officials implied that his administration would try to coerce States to use DHS’s citizenship lists to purge voters.

Mr. Trump’s fellow Republicans are fighting to keep control of Congress in the November 3 midterms. *(With inputs from AP)*

Wild wonders



Four of the recently-born cheetah quintuplets rest at their enclosure at the zoo in Prague, Czech Republic, on Friday. AP

Afghan Taliban-Pakistan ties unravel over TTP, border strikes and more

ANALYSIS

Reuters
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan’s air force struck 10 locations in Afghanistan on Thursday, its second round of strikes in four days after three months of relative quiet along the two countries’ 2,600-km border.

Islamabad said it struck militant hideouts in retaliation for drones launched from Afghanistan. Kabul denied sending the drones and said the seven Afghan fatalities in strikes this week were all civilians.

Here is what is driving the latest escalation, and why previous attempts to contain it have failed.

Islamabad initially viewed the Taliban govern-

ment as a potential ally when it returned to power in Afghanistan in 2021. Then-Prime Minister Imran Khan applauded the Taliban’s return, saying Afghans had “broken the shackles of slavery.”

Blame game

Pakistani frustration soon mounted, however, as militants launched widening insurgencies in Pakistan’s southwest and northwest.

Pakistan has since accused its arch-rival India and the Taliban-run government in Kabul of providing the militants with funds and weapons as well as a safe haven in Afghanistan. The Afghan Taliban and the Indian government deny these allegations.

Frustration in Islamabad spilled into cross-border

fighting last year when Pakistan carried out an air strike on the Afghan capital Kabul in October, targeting the head of the Pakistani Taliban militant group, Pakistani security officials said at the time.

The Pakistani Taliban, a group that operates separately from the Afghan Taliban that run the government in Kabul, later said their leader survived the strike.

Pakistan has also accused the Afghan Taliban of hosting Baloch insurgents, an armed movement seeking independence for the southwestern province of Balochistan.

A first ceasefire, signed in Doha in October, soon faltered. Clashes reached a peak in intensity this spring when hundreds



Caught in the crossfire: Funeral prayers for the deceased in the aftermath of a Pakistani strike in Afghanistan’s Kunar province. AFP

were killed in shelling and air strikes. In the deadliest incident, more than 400 people were killed in one of the Pakistani air strikes on Kabul, which the Afghan Taliban said hit a drug rehabilitation centre.

Islamabad defended the strikes as having “precisely targeted military installa-

tions and terrorist support infrastructure.”

Chinese-mediated talks produced a ceasefire in March that quelled the fighting but again postponed a resolution of the underlying dispute.

Nearly three months of relative quiet ended last week with two major mili-

tant attacks in northwestern Pakistan, killing at least 30 people, including 15 police officials and 6 soldiers.

At least 8 militants, including suicide bombers, killed 24 people, including 15 police officials, at a police facility in northwestern Kohat district last Friday.

An Islamist militant group - Shura Ittehad-ul-Mujahideen led by militant commander Hafiz Gul Bahadur - claimed the attack.

Two days later, on Sunday, an exchange of fire with militants killed 4 soldiers and 2 officers in adjacent Hangu district.

Key belligerents

Pakistan’s widening insurgencies are waged by competing groups with different support bases and ideologies but a common

enemy in the Pakistani state.

Most recent attacks by militants in northwestern Pakistan have been attributed to Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), commonly known as the Pakistani Taliban. It was formed in 2007 by a group of Islamist outfits from the Pashtun ethnic group operating in northwestern Pakistan, which borders Afghanistan.

TTP fighters also fought alongside the Afghan Taliban in Afghanistan and sheltered Afghan fighters in Pakistan, forging a close bond over the Afghan Taliban’s 20-year insurgency.

In recent years, the group’s attacks have primarily targeted Pakistani security forces rather than civilians, allowing it to make inroads into local

communities. The leader of the Shura Ittehad-ul-Mujahideen group that claimed responsibility for last week’s attack in Kohat - Hafiz Gul Bahadur - once hosted al Qaeda and Arab Islamist fighters, said Abdul Basit, an analyst at Singapore’s S. Rajaratnam School of International Studies.

The group initially focused attacks on U.S. and NATO forces in Afghanistan, but turned against Pakistan after its military conducted a major offensive around 2015 targeting a safe haven of the group in North Waziristan district, Mr. Basit said. That pushed the group’s fighters into Afghanistan.

The long-term repercussions of that shift are still playing out today, said Mr. Basit.

A IN-X

